

Speaking quý 2.2022 – Realieltsexams

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PART 1

Topic 1: Work and studies (always in use)

IDIOMS ABOUT WORK:

1. to be between jobs (to be unemployed)
2. to work one's fingers to the bone (to work very hard)
3. to go the extra mile (to go beyond what is necessary)
4. to learn the ropes (to learn how to do a particular job or task)
5. to be a change of pace (to be a variation in routine)

IDIOMS THAT CAN BE USED TALKING ABOUT STUDIES:

1. to miss the boat (to lose an opportunity to do something by being slow to act):
I've missed the boat for the fall semester, so

1. Do you work or are you a student?

I've been working as an English teacher for about 15 years now, and for the last 10 years I've specialized exclusively in teaching IELTS. And I absolutely love what I do. Of course, sometimes I feel tired and emotionally drained, especially when I have to mark my students' essays until midnight... but I just don't see myself being happier doing anything else.

2. What work do you do? What subjects are you studying?

I'm a student, and this is my final year at school. Now I'm working hard in order to get passing grades to enter college in Canada. If everything is ok, six months from now I'll already be studying there. I want to major in Journalism as I like writing essays and articles and want to work for some famous magazine or newspaper. I'm going to do a three-year course at X college.

3. Why did you choose that job?

Well, I guess the primary reason why I decided to pursue a career in Finance was that I really loved Maths at school as I was always good at numbers. And because of this, I thought it was the only possible choice I could make. So it wasn't a tough decision. And, thank God, I have never regretted it.

4. Why did you choose to study that subject?

Back in the day when I was a high school student, I had an idea that I might like to do something related to fashion, but my parents insisted on my choosing Accounting. Frankly, I wish I hadn't listened to them as I don't really enjoy being an accountant.

5. Do you like your job?

I do. Mainly because it's never boring. I love challenging tasks. In fact, the more challenging, the better. Of course, I usually spend a lot of time and energy, put a lot of effort in order to complete such tasks successfully, but job satisfaction that it gives me significantly outweighs the hours, the stress and the hard work. Among other things, there's nothing to complain about as my remuneration is more than adequate, let alone all the perks that my employer provides.

6. Is there anything you dislike about your job?

Well, I hate that I often have to work against the clock to meet deadlines and it seems that I'll never be able to escape this constant rat race. I feel this jam-packed schedule is robbing me of my life.

7. What was your dream job when you were young?

Oh, when I was younger, I wanted to either become a CEO of a big company or be selfemployed. I was really sure that this would bring me an adequate remuneration and, as a result, a sense of satisfaction. What is more, understood that I was good at problem-solving and managing people, could take on responsibility and work under pressure, which was very important for pursuing. such careers.

8. Have you changed your mind on your dream job?

Well, on the whole, 'no' as this is what I still dream about. However, now I realize that there are quite a lot of things in this career which I didn't think about at a younger age, for example, the fact that working under pressure is robbing people of their life, taking them from their families and pushing them to participate in the rat race in order to get recognition and good money.

9. What do you like about your studies?

I will probably sound a bit nerdy, but I'm happy that school provides me with an opportunity to acquire knowledge about things I didn't know before. I guess that most subjects, we are taught, will help us to succeed in the future. So I never miss lessons and complete all the assignments on time.

10.What do you dislike about your studies?

As a high school student, I can safely say that I dislike school very strongly mainly because the teachers pile so much work onto us that we hardly get 5 hours of sleep a night during an average school week. You see, no matter when I go to bed, I have to wake up early. because my classes usually start at 8 am. To top it off, most subjects are boring and irrelevant to our future careers. So it causes a lot of stress, making me and my fellow students reluctant to study.

Topic 2: Hometown (always in use)

1. Please describe your hometown a little?

Well, Delhi is the capital of India and by far the largest city in the country. It's a denselypopulated place, so the city is always crowded and noisy. Also, Delhi has the highest number of vehicles, therefore traffic congestion is a norm here. Also, it has a very rich history. For this reason, it's really popular with tourists who come to

visit our wonderful temples and experience Indian culture. It's never boring to live here as the city provides a wide array of entertainment options. It is also home to our government and all major institutions.

2. What is your town well-known for?

You see, as it's an industrial city, I'm afraid, there's nothing it can boast of. There are neither ancient buildings nor other places of interest that could possibly attract tourists. However, it is in my city that the best shoes are produced.

3. Do you like your hometown?

Yeah, it is never boring no matter what your interest. It's a large city, so you can easily find where to go and what to do. One thing I particularly like about it is although it is vast, there are a thousand small and intimate places there such as peaceful gardens and small friendly restaurants.

4. Is that a big city or a small place?

It's neither small nor big. Actually, it largely depends on what city you compare it with. I would say it's big enough to provide city dwellers with all necessary facilities, whereas it's nowhere near as large as New York or Sydney, for example.

5. How long have you been living there?

Well, I've been living there since I was born. At times I leave the city just for a while when I go on holidays.

6. Do you think you will continue living there for a long time?

Every time an opportunity to move to a different place turns up, I come to realise that I want to be here above everywhere else as the city is rich in everything you could possibly desire. There are lots of things to do and places to go. What is most important for me is that X is the city of infinite possibilities for ambitious and career driven people like me as a lot of large international companies have chosen it for their headquarters.

7. Would you like to live in the countryside in the future?

Oh-no! Not until I retire! I'm only 25 and dreaming of a high-flying career, but I'm afraid that living in the countryside will leave my career in tatters. Besides, I'm a very active and sociable person, so I think I will be bored to death being deprived of an active social life and abundance of entertainment options a big city provides.

8. Have you ever lived in the countryside?

Do you ever spend time in the countryside? Well, this isn't what I'm dreaming of. I'd rather say I don't mind swapping city life for a rural idyll. I'm tired of the constant rat race and I'll definitely enjoy a slower pace of life. Also, I want to live in a house with multiple rooms, a garage and swimming pool which is obviously not possible until I move out of the city.

9. What is the difference between living in the countryside and the city?

I guess that the most striking difference is that in the countryside there isn't much traffic even during rush hours. Again, as there are fewer vehicles emitting exhaust fumes, rural areas are nowhere near as polluted as urban ones. So the air is definitely fresher. This is why it's highly likely that people living in the country live longer. However, there may be a number of people who won't appreciate these benefits as there aren't many opportunities for professional growth and the choice of facilities is limited.

10. What do people living in the countryside like to do?

What do you like to do in the countryside?

There's generally not much to do in the countryside, especially in the winter, so I'm sure the majority of young people like to chat with their friends online or play computer games. They may also like to get together in order to play football, ride bicycles or explore the surroundings. This is because if children are not glued to their devices, they usually have active pastimes. The more adventurous, the better. Again, as the number of recreational facilities is severely limited in the countryside, it seems to me that the most popular activity with adults is having barbeque parties or just chatting with their neighbours over the fence.

11. How has your town changed over the last 20 years?

Oh, I would say it has undergone sweeping changes 'cause those who haven't been there for a long time can hardly recognise it. First of all, the general quality of the city landscape has improved, so it's way more beautiful now. For instance, many ancient buildings have been restored and modern ones have been erected. Therefore, it has turned into a remarkable tourist attraction

Topic 3: Art (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do you like painting or drawing?

Oh, I really enjoy it. It is so relaxing. It always calms my mind and helps me forget my worries. Plus, it's a great way to fight boredom. I often draw while waiting for someone or queuing.

2. What kinds of things do you like to draw?

Well, I can't say I enjoy drawing something in particular. I like to draw everything I see. These can be people, animals, flowers or foods. I just see someone or something that catches my attention. I start drawing, and do it as long as it brings me joy.

3. Is it easy to learn how to draw?

I'm sure it is, but only if you're positive and have the confidence and willingness to learn. One more thing that makes it really easy, to my mind, is taking a drawing course... and, of course, practicing a lot

4. What do you know about paintings?

Well, not too much and not too little, I would say. For example, I know that there are different painting styles and techniques, that paintings can be created on different supports, in other words, different surfaces such as canvas, primed hardboard, wood or paper, and with different brushes for different kinds of paint and to produce different kinds of lines. Also, I know that the most common types of paint used by artists are acrylic, oil, water-mixable oil, watercolor and pastel, and that color theory is one of the fundamentals of painting, a guide to how colors interact, complement or contrast with one another.

5. Have you learned drawing or painting?

Oh yes, I can say that I have as I took time to do it every single day in my childhood practicing hard and never getting discouraged either from my parents or my Art teachers.

6. Do you like visiting museums and art galleries?

Do you often visit museums?

When was the last time you visited a museum?

Definitely, I do. I enjoy visiting museums and art galleries because they are a great way to spend time with friends and family learning something new about different time periods and discussing thoughts and opinions with each other. What's more, museums make me think, which I really like and art galleries clear my mind and boost my own creativity.

Topic 4: Mirrors (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. How often do you use a mirror?

2. Do you like looking at yourself in a mirror?

Oh, I use a mirror almost every other minute. For instance, one of the first things I do in the morning is look in the mirror. It is not because I enjoy looking at myself. It is just simply unavoidable. I go to the bathroom, I look up, and there I am. So I always look in a mirror while brushing my teeth, washing my face and brushing my hair. I also use it while I'm driving to see what's happening around my car. I also look at myself while I'm working out in the gym to make sure I do exercises correctly. It's also unavoidable when I'm in a locker room at a sports center. Actually, I always give a quick glance in a mirror if there's one nearby.

3. Do you use a mirror before buying clothing?

Well, frankly speaking, there's no point using changing room mirrors as most of them lie. For example, they take a dress size off you. They make you look taller and thinner than you are. So you look at yourself and think you've found the perfect dress as it looks fabulous. Then you get home and look in your own mirror and discover it's actually a disaster.

4. What functions does a mirror have?

Do you think a mirror is a good decoration?

I believe its main function is to let you compare what you look like to what you think you should look like and make appropriate changes if necessary. For example, you may give a quick glance in the mirror to check your hair and makeup, especially during those precious moments when you want to look and feel your best. Also, some mirrors can really enhance decor and make a room brighter and bigger-looking. Oh, I nearly forgot to say that mirrors are vital for safe driving as they allow you to observe what is happening around your car. And it's really important to use side mirrors and a rear view one before you start to speed up, slow down, change direction, turn or stop.

5. Have you ever bought a mirror?

Sure. I bought a full length mirror to place on the floor in the entrance hall to look at myself from head to toe before I leave home to make sure I look good. I bought one more mirror to hang on the wall in the bathroom so that I could look at myself while brushing my teeth or doing my hair.

And, of course, I bought several compact mirrors while traveling abroad as they make wonderful gifts.

Topic 5: Dreams (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do you remember your dreams when you wake up?

Oh, yeah, but only if they were so beautiful or bizarre that captured my attention, or if they happened right before I woke up.

2. Do you think dreams will affect life?

Do you think dreams have special meanings?

Well, I guess they will. Dreams can affect our behavior and mood for the following day. They can serve as a guide to our emotions that we sometimes can't express. They help us work through stress, fear, anger, self doubt and guilt. So, yeah, they definitely have an influence on our life, our health and even our relationships with other people.

3. Do you like hearing other people's dreams?

Do you share your dreams with others?

Oh, yeah. I find it fascinating. It's really interesting for me to ferret other's dreams out as well as get a deeper perspective of their personality. What's more, listening to other's dreams is often enjoyable 'cause dreams can be pretty amusing at times.

4. Do you want to learn more about dreams?

Well, I'm not sure I would like to get deep knowledge of dreams, but I would definitely like to know what dreams are and why we have them, what they mean, what purpose they serve and, of course, if we can control them or not.

Topic 6: Emails (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do you write many letters?

A great many, actually. I write them almost all the time at work 'cause it's the fastest and easiest tool for business communication both inside and outside the office.

2. How often do you write letters or emails?

I write plenty of them almost all the time at work 'cause it's the fastest and easiest tool for business communication both inside and outside the office.

3. Do you prefer to write letters by hand or to use a computer?

I like writing letters 'cause they are more personal and add a human touch to the relationship making every word count, but I mostly write emails because they are fast and save a lot of my time in the decision making process.

4. What are the differences between letters and emails?

I guess the main difference between them is that letters are written by hand and emails are typed on a computer. What is more, letters require our undivided attention and show how much we care while emails are easy to use and can be delivered around the world at once.

5. What do you usually write about?

When would you send emails to others?

I generally write about something that occupies or moves me, about the changes that are happening at work or in the country, about recent events. From time to time I also write about something I don't have enough courage to face.

6. Is it hard to think of what to write?

For me it is, unfortunately. The first reason for that is my very poor imagination and the second is the fact that it's hard for me to focus on writing to let ideas come.

7. What kind of letter or email do you think is the hardest to write?

I guess the hardest letters are the ones rejected. someone or stating that a family member or close friend has died. It's also really hard to write the kind of letters and letters in which you say goodbye to someone you don't want to leave.

Topic 7: Sports (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do you like watching sports programs on TV?

Yeah, I love watching sports programs on TV 'cause it's a lot more comfortable than doing so at a stadium. First of all, a cozy seat or couch is much better than a cheap plastic seat with minimal legroom. And you're not standing in long lines for food and toilet like you do when you watch it at a stadium. Plus, you can watch a game with the sound off or turn down the volume if you don't want to hear crowds cheering as well as stadium or arena music. What's more, I know that some people go to the game and then watch it on TV after they get home because they feel they miss being there too much as there's no replay.

2. Who do you like to watch live sports games with?

Well, I enjoy watching live sports games with my father and brother as it brings us closer to each other. Plus, we have a really good time together with food, beverages and entertainment all in one place. And of course, it also makes the game much more special for the three of us.

3. Do you like to watch live sports games?

What is the difference between watching sports events at home and at the stadium? Well, watching a game at home gives people more comfort as they don't have to queue for food or toilets for hours, get cold if the weather is not really good and waste hours after the game to get out of the parking lots. Instead, they can enjoy the warmth of their home, the company of their close friends and unlimited snack breaks during long timeouts and halftime. They can also easily pause the game and not miss out on any of the action and, of course, replay the episodes they want to see one more time. Watching a match at the stadium people get first hand touch of the event and create long-lasting memories of fun and entertainment. atmosphere created by a large number of fans. One more advantage they get being at the stadium is a chance to focus on anything that catches their attention as they are not restricted to a particular view of the camera, which is unfortunately impossible watching a game on TV. Oh, and the last difference I see is the fact that going to the stadium can cost people quite a bit of money, while enjoying the game at home is for free.

4. Do you like sports?

Oh yeah, I do as it's the only way for me to release stress and improve my general health.

What's more, it's my favorite way to make friends and enjoy social interaction. So, definitely yes!

5. Do most people in your country like sports?

Well, I guess yes as sport helps people stay in shape and in some cases even find a purpose in life. Moreover, playing sports makes life more interesting and filled with positive emotions 'cause sports communication brings fun into everyday routine. So, yeah, I am more than sure that most people in my country like it.

6. Did you do any sports when you were young?

Oh, I am really fond of playing tennis as it is one of the most dynamic sports requiring my total involvement. It encourages interaction, communication and just plain fun and is a great stress reliever which makes it even more loveable.

7. What sports do people in your country like to play?

Oh, I would say all kinds of ball games. People in my country are fond of football because it has simple rules, can be played just with a ball almost anywhere, is very entertaining to watch and play and very short which makes viewers actively involved in the game from the beginning to the end. There are also a lot of basketball and volleyball fans.

Topic 8: Taking photos (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do you like photography?

I can safely say I have a passion for it. At some point of my life photography changed the way I see the world around me. What I mean is when I look at the world through my camera lens, I see the details. otherwise, would go unnoticed. Now I notice light, shapes, colors, textures, people, buildings, trees, flowers... It's a great way to explore the world. Once you start noticing details, you inevitably start to see how much beauty is all around you.

2. Do you like to take photographs?

For me, photography is the best way to relieve stress. Once I start taking pictures, it's really hard for me to stop. I really quickly get immersed in the process and completely forget about my problems. The only thing I worry about is how to make a perfect shot.

3. How did you become interested in photography?

Well, I fell in love with photography when I joined an interest group for traveling on Facebook. Every day its members shared beautiful photographs of nature and exotic places which they had been to. I was especially fascinated by micro images of flowers and insects and magnificent seascapes at dusk. One day I asked myself why I couldn't take such beautiful pictures. So now I'm a keen photographer.

4. How do you keep your photos?

Well, I usually store photos on my computer and there's a folder for each year and event. Also, I have a backup copy of all my_photos on an external hard drive. This way, even if my computer suddenly crashes, or gets stolen, I will still have my photos safe and sound.

5. Do you ever delete or, if on paper, throw away any of your photos?

Oh, it's better to ask me if there are any photos that don't delete. Unfortunately I'm a perfectionist, therefore I don't like less than perfect pictures. So if I see that a photo has poor quality, I immediately delete it. Also, I don't like multiple photos of the same kind as nobody will look at all of them unless they want to train their eyes to spot minor differences. I'm joking.

Topic 9: Cinemas (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. How often do you go to a cinema to watch a movie?

Well, I go to the cinema every time there is a new release. My friends call me a movie freak but I just enjoy it. watching films on the big screen and getting pulled into the sound and color in a way that can't be felt at home.

2. Do people in your country like to go to a cinema to watch a film?

I guess yes as there are always a lot of people at the cinema. Cinemas are in great demand as they let people focus on the movie and not get distracted, which people value. What's more, it's a good way to spend time out.

3. Do you like to watch movies alone or with your friends?

Do you like to go to the cinema with your friends?

Personally I like to watch films alone as I get to watch exactly what I want. What's more, it's a kind of the ultimate 'me time' with no conversations and other distractions.

4. What kinds of movies do you like best?

Well, I guess action films for sure. They attract me with their non-stop motion, spectacular rhythm and pacing. What's more, I like their two-dimensional 'good guy' heroes battling 'bad guys' as the age-old struggle between good and evil is always interesting.

Topic 10: Street markets (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Are there many street markets in your country?

Oh yeah, I'd say many as there is at least one street market in each neighborhood in cities or towns and sometimes a couple of markets in every village. You see, street markets have always been central to the cultural and economic history of my country. So, there are a lot of them everywhere.

2. What do street markets sell?

What do people usually buy at street markets?

I think people usually go to street markets in order to buy foods like fruits, vegetables, meat and fish, flowers, sweets, paintings and even antique stuff.

3. What is the difference between street markets and supermarkets?

Do you prefer shopping in a shopping mall or at a street market?

Well, supermarkets are self-service stores while markets are places where sellers serve buyers. One more difference is that supermarkets are indoor shops while street markets are located outdoors. Also, the conditions inside supermarkets are more comfortable than those of the street markets, I mean that shops are always warm in winter and cool in summer. And the most important difference, to my mind, is that produce at street markets is more fresh, and sometimes more diverse, than that in supermarkets.

4. Do many people go to street markets in your country?

Well, quite a few, actually. People like visiting street markets as there is always a variety of products to everyone's liking and budget. What's more, the produce there is always fresh and usually lasts longer than that from the supermarket.

5. Do you like going to street markets?

I do, but not very often. I don't really like crowded and noisy places, but at the same time I adore buying fresh high-quality products. Oh, I also adore to bargain at the markets, so I'd rather say I like visiting them than not.

Topic 11: Mobile phones (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What was your first mobile phone?

Oh, I will never forget it. It was the Nokia 3310, a compact handset which gained a reputation of being indestructible because I changed several phones which stopped working after a year or so, but my old Nokia which I continued using was like new. Those cool modern devices were nowhere near as durable as my old Nokia.

2. How often do you use your mobile phone?

Do you use your mobile phone for texting or calls?

Well, I guess I am awake all the time. I use it for making and receiving calls, texting my friends and customers, getting and sharing news on social networks

sites, checking my email messages and even doing online banking. I also take photos with my phone and keep track of calendar events. So yeah, almost all day long.

3. Can you describe your mobile phone?

Recently I bought a Samsung Galaxy XX which I'd been dreaming of for a long time. I think it's an excellent smartphone. What I mean is it's a typical smartphone by today's standards as it's a touchscreen device which is thin and light, but it's obviously of much higher quality than many other Android devices. I'm more than satisfied with the quality of photos and videos. The sound is excellent too. So there's, actually, nothing to complain about.

4. Would you buy a new one in the future?

Oh yeah, definitely I would. Just to be updated with technology and improve the functionality of the phone. I am sure everyone would take a chance to get a significantly better phone at the earliest opportunity, and I am not an exception.

5. How has your mobile phone changed your life?

Oh, first of all, it has made my life much more convenient 'cause it provides me with an easy and fast way of communication, enabling me to do various tasks all at the same time and freeing me from the constraints of space. What's more, it has given me a chance to enjoy social media on the go, which is really cool.

Topic 12: Time management (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. How do you usually organize your time?

Well, I start my day only after completing my time plan. The first thing I do is identify my priorities and assign time to any activity or conversation important for my success. I try to stick to the time boundaries by eliminating activities that waste my time and prevent me from staying focused.

2. Are you good at organizing time?

I guess I am, because I always meet my deadlines. At the beginning of each week I make a list of the tasks I need to accomplish, identify my priorities for a day and a week, peg a time limit to each task and do my best to stick to these time boundaries by crossing things off the list as they are completed and trying to speed up when I see that I am behind my schedule.

3. Are you good at organizing time?

I'm afraid I'm not. I don't always meet my deadlines and procrastinate. I often fail to manage distractions such as TV, emails, Facebook. Also, I sometimes take on too much 'cause I can't say 'no' to people.

4. What is the hardest part about making plans?

Well, I think there's no one-size-fits-all answer to this question as all people are different, and the challenges they face while making plans are also different. For some people, the most difficult part of planning is prioritizing among their available options, for others it is identifying their actual desired outcomes. For me personally, the hardest part is crunching through all the different combinations of possible actions to select the best overall set. So, it depends.

5. What is the latest plan that you made?

Well, the latest plan I've made is to enter a university abroad. So, I'm currently learning all the information about studying in different countries and trying to find the country and the university I'd like to study in.

Topic 13: Websites (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What kinds of websites do you often visit?

Oh, I really often visit Gmail, an email website to check my email when I'm on my computer. Also, I am a frequent visitor to social networking sites such as Facebook, Instagram and TikTok as they help me stay up-to-date with news and current events, make social connections and find funny and entertaining content.

2. What kinds of websites are popular in your country?

Well, undoubtedly, the most loved and preferred choice of websites in my country is social networking sites such as Facebook, Instagram and TikTok as they are an epicenter of all kinds of human activity, be it in the sphere of business, education or entertainment. Though, I should also name shopping sites, business sites and educational sites among the most visited websites in X.

3. What is your favorite website?

Oh, my favorite website (though it's also an app, Instagram as it offers a flurry of benefits to enjoy. This site is an inexhaustible source of breaking news and so potent a tool both for social interaction and business activity. I really love to fill up my free time with all the information I can find there.

Topic 14: Losing and finding things (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What should people do if they find something?

Well, I guess, first of all, hand the item in at the location of finding or leave their contact details at the place of find so that the owner may contact them. Also, I think people should put up a notice near to where they found the item i.e. place an advert or posters on a community notice board at the location of find as well as create a post on local social media pages such as Facebook, Twitter or Instagram. One more thing I would recommend people to do in this case is report found property to the police or if they find some documents, return them directly to the issuing authority or provider.

2. Is it ok to keep an item that you found?

No. No way! How is that different from stealing? Whatever you find is a piece of property that belongs to someone else. This means it's not yours. And, by definition, holding or possessing property that you know does not belong to you is stealing. So, even though you did not steal the item by taking it directly from its owner, keeping an item that you found, and not trying to return it, is a form of stealing. So, at first, it's illegal. You should turn over whatever you found to the local police. Also, to my mind, it's morally wrong to take something that someone else lost. What if this person spent life savings to buy it? Or what if this item meant a lot to this person? You can only keep it for some time if you are going to make a sincere effort to return it to the rightful owner. Otherwise, as I've said before, you should hand it in to the police or lost and found.

3. What should people do to find what they lost?

Of course, what people should do in order to find a lost item very much depends on what they lost and where they lost it. But in most cases, all people need to do is determine the last time they saw it, return to the place where they last saw it and repeat their way to the place where they found it missing. If a person lost something in a public place, I guess they should ask people around if they saw the lost item, visit the lost-and-found office, if available, or inform the police about the loss. If a person lost a phone, they should try to hunt it down using Google maps, IMEI number or some app that will help them locate their device and lock it until they get it back. If a person loses a key, the best thing to do first is to search the bag and pockets thoroughly. At least, these are the things that usually work for me when I lose something.

4. What things do people usually find?

Well, I guess the ones other people usually lose. I mean keys, wallets, ID cards, cell phones, sunglasses, laptops and other easily misplaced items often left in public places such as shops, parks, sports centers, or on public transportation such as the bus or subway. I also know quite a few cases when people found umbrellas, gloves, earrings and even lunch boxes and shopping bags. So, you never know.

5. What things do people often lose?

Well, I think that phones, keys and glasses top the list of the most commonly lost items. Running second to them are battery chargers, stationery, wallets and documents, especially passports and driver's licenses. Oh, and umbrellas as well. If we also talk about what people lose at home, I am more than sure that the leader is a TV remote control, as I also lose it every now and then.

Topic 15: Daily routine (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. How do you organize your study time?

What is your daily study routine?

First of all, I work out how much time I have available, and when. Then I list all the subjects I need to study and the tasks in hand, work out priorities between them, set targets for each task and do my best to stick to the timetable.

2. Do you ever change your plans?

Have you ever changed your routine?

Oh yes, I often change my plans when something goes wrong along the way and I feel I got stuck in a rut. I also make changes when new opportunities arise and I see some better alternatives to the plans I had.

3. What's your favorite time of the day?

Oh, I adore evenings as it's the only time of the day. I can spend time with my family and friends. What is more, evenings let me enjoy everything I do as I don't have to hurry, which I value a lot.

4. Do you like to plan what you will do each day?

Oh yeah, I really enjoy planning my days as it makes my life more predictable and, as a result, less stressful. It gives me the right direction, motivates me during the day and keeps me disciplined. It also increases my efficiency and helps produce quality work.

5. Please describe your typical daily routine?

Oh, I usually wake up at around 6 am, wash my face, brush my teeth, drink a glass of lemon water and go for a run. I normally run for about 1 hour, then get back home, have a shower, get dressed, do my hair and put on make-up. Then I prepare and have my breakfast, and go to work. At the office I usually work on a current project, have a couple of meetings and discuss some work issues with my colleagues. After office hours I have a short walk back home, make and have my dinner, unwind a bit either watching TV or surfing the net, have a soothing bath and go to bed. That's what my typical day is like.

6. What do you usually do at this time of day?

Well, at this time I normally have my extra classes or, if I am lucky enough, a walk in the park with my friends.

7. Do you usually do the same things at the same time each day?

At least I try to. Doing so helps me manage my time, increases my efficiency and ensures timely completion and deliverable results, which is important for me.

8. What do you want to change in your daily routine?

Well, I would really like to wake up later, work less, rest more and have enough time for hobbies but it's unlikely to happen in the very near future.

Topic 16: Cars (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do you like to sit in front or back when traveling by car?

Well, if we travel during the day, I always choose the front seat as keeping my eyes on the road prevents me from experiencing nausea while traveling. Though, usually opt for a back seat if we travel at night as it's more comfortable to nap in the back.

2. Why do you like traveling by car?

Oh, I like traveling by car because it always means speed and comfort for me. For example, it prevents me from worrying about my kids bothering other passengers or from deciding what things we just can't take with us because of some baggage weight restrictions. Well, and one more reason why I like traveling by car is because it is typically the cheapest way to travel inside the country.

3. What is the farthest place you have traveled to by car?

Well, the farthest place I've traveled to by car was Paris. That drive took me across a few other countries and in general lasted a few days. I was exhausted when we arrived in Paris but it was definitely worth it.

4. When do you travel by car?

Well, I usually travel by car when it's the fastest or the only way to get to my destination. Or when I want to travel at my own pace making stops whenever and wherever I want as well as changing my plans as I go pulling off the road and seeing the sights.

Topic 17: Memory (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Are you good at memorizing things?

Yes, I think I can say so. I have no difficulty in memorizing information 'cause I use a number of simple memorisation strategies. For example, I always try to review information just before I go to sleep 'cause it has been proven that our brain processes and stores information while we sleep. Also, I'm an auditory learner, so for me the most effective way to memorize information is by hearing it. So to memorize, say, a poem, I read it out loud to myself several times. Sometimes I record it and then play it again and again.

2. Why do people often forget small things?

Well, I guess because of insufficient focus, time and attention spent on them. People just don't register small stuff in their memory in the first place and, as a result, easily forget it.

3. How can you make sure you don't forget things?

Oh, I think I can do it in a variety of ways. For instance, I can write all plans down on my ToDo list or put them on my calendar and then just check what I have already done and what I still have to complete. I can also set reminders for things to do or try using some app like Evernote or Slice Planner to remember everything I need. But the best thing I can do, to my mind, is develop specific habits that will ensure that things don't slip between the cracks.

PART 2

Topic 1: Course that impressed you (topic for all test dates till 31 Prev | Next August 2022)

Describe a lesson that you remember well You should say:

when it was
where it was what
you did what
your teacher did
why it was special

Part 3 - 'Remembering things'

Many moons ago when I was a child I attended an English language course at a language center.

I'm convinced that one of the reasons why that course still remains in my memory is that our teacher did her best to perfectly arrange everything. Although there was nothing unusual at all, I vividly remember almost each class as our teacher created an unforgettable and pleasant atmosphere.

A typical lesson consisted of several interconnected stages each of which was filled with an awesome activity, so there was no chance to get bored. I remember I did a lot of different things with my groupmates. Firstly, the teacher carefully checked the homework assignment, which was an indispensable part of every lesson. It took quite a long time to ask various questions. The teacher answered all the questions, which helped me get a good understanding of the grammar points we dealt with. After that we played fun educational games. As I love interacting with people, I really enjoyed those oral activities. They were designed to be done together with classmates so I greatly developed my communication skills. In addition, I enjoyed doing crossword puzzles, that's why when I was told to do that at the lesson, I was really glad. At the end of the lesson, we got a challenging task which was to compose spooky stories in English. I am fond of creative writing, so it was a real pleasure for me when I got that task. Then every student read their story aloud. The teacher praised us from time to time, therefore our language confidence significantly increased, and I bet everybody was convinced that their story was a masterpiece.

To my mind, that lesson was special because I had a wonderful opportunity to develop my communication and writing skills and got a good understanding of tricky

grammatical structures. Moreover, it's worth mentioning that it was only after this lesson that I started feeling an overwhelming desire to learn English. Every minute of the lesson was incredibly interesting to me. In other words, the teacher aroused my interest in the English language.

Topic 2: Gift you want to buy (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a gift you'd like to buy for your friend You should say:

what gift you want to
buy who you'd like to
give it to why you'd to
buy a gift
why you've chosen that gift

Part 3 - 'Gifts'

A few weeks ago, one of my close friends moved into a new apartment. So it's perfectly natural that she wants to present her new home to her friends, and for this, she's going to throw a housewarming party next month.

When I received an invitation, my first thought was 'Oh my God. What gift shall I give her?' To me, choosing the perfect gift is always a daunting task 'cause I hate giving something that will go unappreciated. For me, it's really important to give a gift a person is dreaming of. But the element of surprise is as important as the acceptance of the gift. That's why I never ask a giftreceiver about what they want or need directly. As a result, it usually takes time to find out what a person wants and find the perfect gift for them.

Fortunately, this time my friend literally saved me when she created a wishlist using Google Docs so that everyone can choose the gift of their choice and budget, but she won't see what people are getting her 'cause she set me as the owner of the spreadsheet. So she has no access to her own document. And we'll be able to keep all activity a secret until she starts unwrapping presents. So nothing will ruin the surprise. What's more, his system helps prevent the receipt of duplicate or unwanted gifts and allows us, gift-givers, to figure out which stores have the items she needs.

All I did was open the document, look through the whole list and choose the gift I liked the most. And it was also the one that fitted my gift budget. I'm going to buy her a flatware set for 6. It's quite expensive. She told me she'd added some pricey items to the list she doesn't expect to get them. Just imagine how surprised and delighted she will be when I give her the gift that she expects the least.

Topic 3: Story you remember (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a story someone told you and you remember

should say: what this story is about
who told you this story
when you heard it
why you remember it

Part 3 - 'Stories'

Last year in the winter my father was going to go outside wearing just slippers, trousers and a jumper. I told him to put on his winter coat, boots and a hat as I was afraid he would freeze to death. He said he would be back in 5 minutes. And he told me a story about a man who spent a whopping 20 hours lying paralyzed in snow outside his home and didn't even have any frostbite. I was amazed to hear that. I asked how it was possible. And it appeared that the man was saved by his dog.

So, there was some man who decided to go outside for a moment, just like my father. He wasn't going to stay out in the cold for a long time, that's why he was wearing slippers, trousers and a shirt. But he slipped and broke his neck. He couldn't stand up. He was lying in the snow screaming for help, but nobody could hear him. Luckily, his dog came to him and started barking for help. She kept him warm for about 20 hours by lying on top of him. Also, she kept him awake by licking his hands and face. If he had fallen asleep, he would have been doomed. The dog kept barking for help all night long. Thank God, she alerted the man's neighbor, who called the emergency services, and the man was taken to hospital.

The story moved me, but when my father finished it I asked him to put on warm clothes because we didn't have a dog that would rescue him.

Topic 4: New place you visited (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a new place that you visited You should say:

what place it was

why you went

there what you did

there

how you felt about it

Part 3 - 'New

Before the COVID-19 pandemic started, I visited Dubai Miracle Garden, the world's largest natural flower park, for the first time in my life. I've never been someone who really loves flowers, so I went there just because I wanted to make the most of my trip to the UAE and visit as many popular places as possible. And I have never regretted going there. It is indeed a miracle garden.

I had a good couple of hours wandering around the numerous decorations. There were millions of flowers arranged in colorful arches and patterns. For example, the heart's passage was totally gorgeous as was the flower covered full size aircraft. Also, there was a huge floral clock made of real plants and flowers. There were giant cats, Disney characters, and a flower castle. All of them were totally covered with flowers. You feel like you are in some kind of a fairyland.

I took pictures of flowers and flower displays until I totally ran out of storage space on my phone. Then! just explored the park gasping in amazement every other minute. It's impressive how much work was put in it. If I had to choose one word to describe this amazing place, it would be 'magical'. It was the first and only time I saw so many colorful flowers. I saw the colors | never knew existed. It was truly a feast for the eyes.

When I came home, I was so impressed that I set a picture taken there as the home screen on my phone. So every time I unlock my device, I fondly recall my first (and only) visit to this beautiful place full of color.

Well, nowadays there's so much noise around that sometimes silence is a luxury I can no longer affc time and again I go to some quiet places to not to forget what 'silence' is. Recently I found a nice clearing in a coniferous forest which is just a 20-m drive from the city. This was a magical place whc quietness was almost tangible.

Topic 5: Rule you don't like (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a rule that you don't like You should say:

what it is why you
don't like it what
others feel about it
whether you follow the rule

Part 3 - 'Rules'

What I really dislike is that some hotels don't allow guests to take any food from a hotel's breakfast buffet and restaurants to eat later or to eat, say, on the beach or in the room.

Of course, if people were permitted to take as much food as they want, most hotels would go bankrupt 'cause in hotels that don't have such restrictions some people just bring several containers and clean out the buffet, leaving nothing for the rest of the people in line. I think this is a bit over the top. So if all people acted like this, the rule would be justified.

But there are also many people like me. I would only grab just a few items for later 'cause I prefer to relax with my coffee and breakfast in my room rather than in the breakfast room. I think there is nothing wrong with taking food from a hotel's breakfast room as long as it's the same amount as I would have taken if eating IN the breakfast room. What's more, when you are staying at a hotel, you have paid for the buffet, so there is no difference if you eat a muffin and take another to eat later, or if you eat the two muffins directly.

You know, although I don't think the rules should be obeyed just because they are the rules, I never sneak food into my room. It's not that I'm so law-abiding a person, but I just don't do this. I don't know why.

Topic 6: Interesting city (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe an interesting city You should say: what city it is how you know it what it is famous for why you think it is beautiful

Part 3 - 'Cities, countryside, tourism'

Well, X is the city that I'm in love with. And because I was overwhelmed by its size and beauty, I remember almost every minute that I spent there like it was just yesterday although I went there 2 years ago.

X is a bustling city, the capital of X. It's so large that if you view the city from a tall building, you get the feeling that it doesn't end. And as I've just said it's by far the most beautiful city that I've ever visited. X is divided into two parts, the old town and the modern city, therefore there's an eclectic mix of historic architecture and modern buildings that have bizarre shapes. What is really amazing is that there are no ugly, cooker-cutter buildings in the modern part of the city. Due to a clever use of materials, almost each building has its unique design. There are a lot of beautiful and green zones, too.

I'm a keen walker so I explored the whole city on foot. And I really liked both parts of the city. For example, while walking around its historic part, I am leisurely. explored historically significant architecture, peaceful green spaces, and unique local attractions along the way. You can walk for days and still have something new to see 'cause there are many places of cultural and historical value, and there are countless routes that can be taken in different parts of the city. Sometimes I just walked around the city having no destination in mind. I also visited the observation deck. It's one of the most famous attractions there. I just couldn't miss the opportunity to visit it although it was a bit pricey. So I walked, tried local food, visited famous attractions and enjoyed the beauty around. It really did feel like I was jumping from antiquity into modern times all the + think X is a magical place.

Topic 7: Clothes as a gift (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a piece of clothes that you received as a gift You should say:
when you received the clothes
what the piece of clothes was
like who gave it to you explain
how you feel about it

Part 3 - 'Clothes' Vocabulary Ideas

Oh, there's a crazy story behind my go-to pair of jeans. Once I saw cool jeans in a shop window of a high-street shop and fell for them. However, I didn't dare to go and try them on because everyone knows this shop is for people with deep pockets. Once my husband and I were passing by this shop window. He noticed the way I looked at the jeans and asked me whether I wanted to pop in and try them on. I tried to pretend not to be in the mood for shopping, but he insisted and we entered the shop.

It was an amazing pair of skinny jeans, the ones you have to fight some to put on, but the torment is forgotten as soon as you see yourself in the mirror. These were dark wash blue jeans with sanding. One might think there was nothing special about them as they were stripped of all details which could justify the price. There were neither zippers nor welts. But they elongated the line of my legs and felt like a second skin. They were perfect because I could match them with anything, be it formal, casual, street style or even corporate. I looked at the price tag, understood they cost a fortune and made my husband quickly leave the shop.

However, I couldn't stop thinking about these jeans. One day I realized that I had to buy them no matter what. Well, I borrowed 500 euros from my friend and couldn't wait to purchase them. Much to my disappointment, when I came to the shop, I was told that the jeans had been sold a few days before. I was upset, but I had to put up with this fact somehow. Gradually I stopped thinking about them.

Several weeks later, on my birthday I found a gift box near my bed. Guess what was inside! Those jeans!

Topic 8: Person you follow on social media (topic for all test dates till Prev | Next 31 August 2022)

Describe a person you follow on social media You should say:

who this person is

how you know this

person

what this person posts on social media

explain why you follow this person

Part 3 - 'Social media'

The person I've been following on Instagram for a while is Marina Mogilko. She is a YouTuber with 2 million subscribers, Instagram influencer and entrepreneur. Her YouTube channel is dedicated to learning English. And, actually, this is how I found her.

One day I was looking for an accent reduction course on YouTube. I watched one of her videos, then another one. They were really engaging. I just couldn't stop watching them. I found her personal account on Instagram and started following her.

Her posts proved to be even more interesting than her videos because she wrote a lot about her life in America, described her business strategies, and shared her insights with the audience. So I've been following her on Instagram for almost a year now. I still find her interesting, so I never miss her posts, especially that she writes after attending some events.

I'm sure it is her ideas and beliefs that have helped her achieve the results I'm dreaming about. So I try to apply some of these things to my life. Some of her ideas are totally different from mine, thus, they made me look at things from a different perspective.

Topic 9: Interesting song (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a song that means something special to you You should say:

what this song is about
when you heard this song for the
first time how often you listen to
this song why it is special to you

Part 3 - 'Music'

'I Will Survive' by Diana Ross is a song that is very personal to me. This is a story of a woman that was abandoned by her beloved man. She really vividly describes what it feels like to have your heart broken.

So when I heard this song for the first time (I was a teenager), it touched a nerve as I had just broken up with my boyfriend (or girlfriend). My heart was broken, and I thought I would never love again. She sang about exactly the same feelings that I experienced at that moment. She was afraid, disappointed, frustrated and depressed. I remember I was crying the whole night, but somehow this provided emotional relief. Also, in the song she states that although it hurts, she will be strong and cope with this situation.

I heard it on the radio first and liked it straightaway. Now this song isn't as popular as it was years ago, but this doesn't make it less worth talking about. After that I downloaded it on my computer, and I couldn't stop listening to it until I had learnt it by heart so that I could sing along to the whole song.

It is really difficult to overestimate what impact this song had on me. First of all, it made me understand that whatever happens, life goes on. This insight helped me combat depression, let go of negative emotions and look at my problems from a different perspective. I don't know whether I would have gotten through a sticking point in my life as fast as I did if it hadn't been for this song. Now I don't often listen to it as I don't do it deliberately. But, of course, sometimes I do if I accidentally hear it on the radio.

Topic 10: Special cake you received (topic for all test dates till 31 August Prev | Next 2022)

Describe an occasion when you received a special cake. You should say:

what kind of cake it was
when you had it
who gave it to you
why it was special

Part 3 - 'Food'

Several years ago my boyfriend messed up big time, and I was so angry with him that I didn't even want to listen to his 'I am so sorry. Please forgive me.' He kept saying he would do anything to make me forgive him. And I decided to give him a punishment he deserved. My boyfriend considered cooking to be a cruel form of punishment. I swear. He always said it was easier for him to work all night long than to make an omelet, let alone some exquisite dishes like lasagna or soup.

So I said I would forgive him if he could make my favorite three-tier chocolate biscuit cake. And I told him I would sit and watch him cooking to make sure he didn't cheat.

He found a video recipe on the Internet and just followed all the instructions step by step. First, he baked several cakes and made chocolate mousse. He assembled the cake, stacking the layers onto each other. Also, he experimented with cake decorations a bit (who would've thought) and finally decided to make a chocolate lace collar around the bottom and middle cakes. The cake looked gorgeous. The crumb was delicate and moist, the frosting was rich and creamy and utterly chocolatey. It was filled with buttercream, fresh fruit, and nuts. He sprinkled the top tier of the cake with chocolate curls and dusted it with confectioners sugar.

My jaw dropped to the floor. I just couldn't believe it managed to do it for me.

Topic 11: Person who contributes to the society (topic for all test dates till Prev | Next 31 August 2022)

Describe a person who contributes to the society You should say:

who this person is how

you know the person

how this person helps

others

how you feel about what this person does

Part 3 is 'Jobs'

I'm lucky to be surrounded by many altruistic people who put others before themselves, but the person who deserves the highest praise is a young woman whose name is Diana. I once came across her post on Facebook, which was shared by one of my friends, and I decided to donate to some cause she was raising money for. This is how I found out about her volunteer work. Diana doesn't belong to any organizations. She thinks each of us can and should take initiative to change what we feel is wrong in our society.

We've met several times in person and she told me how it all began. Initially, she found posts of people asking for help, visited them in order to make sure they were

not taking the money under false pretenses and donated money, food or clothes. She helped many people in need, for example, families with many children, cancer patients and elderly people... all who needed both physical and emotional support... But as her individual resources were limited, she decided to raise money and invite people to join her using Facebook

Looking at her, you would never say that she single handedly has raised a lot of money for many good causes, be it helping the poor or the disabled. Not only does she help people, but also makes attempts to protect the environment by organizing community cleanups in different districts of the city. And I guess there is one more really important thing she does by spreading the information about the needy. She inspires people to do good and makes them pay attention to problems our society faces. Otherwise, many of us would ignore the difficulties of others, making tons of excuses such as a lack of time, problems at work, stuff like that. But when people see that she takes it. of her husband and children, goes to work like all of us, they don't even dare to say that they would help if they weren't for something.

Topic 12: Person you like to spend time with (topic for all test dates till 31 Prev | Next August 2022)

Describe a person that you like to spend time with You should say:

who this person is how
you know this person
what you like to do
together
why you like to spend time with this person

Part 3 - 'Getting along with others'

The person I really enjoy spending time with is my. boyfriend Denis. You know, it's like every time I say. 'Goodbye' to him, right after that I start looking forward to the next meeting. This is what, in my opinion, shows how much I like being with him.

To tell the truth, if it hadn't been for his persistence, I wouldn't have even started communicating with him. So, how did it all begin? We met by accident. We went to the same fitness center and saw each other from time to time, but I didn't pay attention to him as he wasn't my type. Once we had small talk at the reception and

after that he befriended me on Facebook. Gradually we started communicating a lot and have become inseparable friends.

Everybody says we are a perfect match as, on the one hand, we have a lot in common, on the other, we are really different and complement each other, so it is always interesting for us to be together. We both like walking in the park. We can speak on the phone till morning as every hour feels like a minute, and I don't realize how time flies when we are together. We often go to the cinema or just stay at home to watch a good film together. He invites me to different cafes and restaurants where we can taste new dishes and just chat. We discuss our plans for the future, visualizing what life will be like when we get married. We like reading books and discussing them. When the weather is bad, we like playing board games such as backgammon or checkers at home.

Actually, it doesn't really matter what we do as we are together. What I know for sure is if it were. him, I would have missed out on so many things. For instance, I wouldn't have jumped with a parachute swum in a cold river. Whatever we do, we always have a good time, laugh and enjoy each other.

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Topic 13: House or apartment you'd like to live in (topic for all test dates till Prev | Next 31 August 2022)

Describe a house or apartment you'd like to live in You should say:

what kind of accommodation it will
be where it will be if it will be big
or small what it will look like

Part 3 - 'Accommodation'

Well, if you'd asked me to describe my dream house a few weeks ago, I would have had no answer. But just several days ago I came across a video on YouTube that showed an unbelievably cool rectangular modern house with a grass backyard and an in-ground pool.

When I saw it, my jaw dropped to the floor. I realized that this is the house of my dreams. So, now I know that the house I'm dreaming of is a straight-lined white house made of concrete, steel and glass or a rectangular cottage with a black glass facade, possibly with multiple decks. Actually, it doesn't really matter whether it

will be white or black. I just want it to be an ultra modern geometric building, without a traditional roof, you got the idea.

It goes without saying that the interior of the house should match its exterior. I think it will be a 2 storey house with a wide open floor plan, high ceilings, and flying. staircase and big floor-to-ceiling windows that let a lot of natural light in. I'd like it to be either in a minimalist style or with some characteristics of a loft style such as massive oak planks, concrete walls, marble panels and some other elements made of natural stone glass and steel.

What's more, there will definitely be remote control heating, lighting, and sound systems, floor heating and cooling, and automatic blinds. Oh, and I nearly forgot one of the most important things... There will be a surrounding. sound system all through the house.

It will definitely be a big house as a small one won't include all the rooms and elements of design that I want to have. I mean tall ceilings, lots of windows, spacious foyers, huge staircases, three or four garages, a kitchen and a dining room, a sun room, walk-in closets and 2 or 3 bedrooms complete with whirlpool tubs and separate showers, laundry rooms, media rooms and a home office. And I think the best place for such a fantastic house would be in the heart of London or New York, for example.

Topic 14: Something you received for free (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a product or service that you got for free You should say:

what it was

how you got

it

how you felt about it

Part 3 - 'Free things'

Just a few days ago I decided to have a quick bite to eat at McDonald's as I didn't have a lot of time to have a meal at a cafe.

So I went to the McDrive and ordered a cheeseburger and small fries. I paid for my order at the first drive through window. And I expected to get my food as soon as I got to the second one as McDonald's guarantees one-minute drive-through service. But no such luck.

I was asked to drive forward, park the car and wait for my order. Well, after 5 minutes of waiting I started getting nervous and decided to get their attention by beeping the car horn. After 10 minutes of waiting, I was going to go to the drive-through window and get a refund. And when I was about to get out of the car, I saw a girl with a takeout bag approaching my car. She sincerely apologized for having kept me waiting for so long and awarded me with a free food voucher on a future McDonald's visit.

Of course, I didn't jump for joy as I was nervous and afraid to be late for my appointment with a doctor, but I was really pleased about it because I felt valued as a customer. No doubt I will be back in the future.

Topic 15: Something that was broken in your home (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe something that was broken in your home and then repaired You should say:

What it is

How it was broken

How it was repaired

How you felt about it

Part 3 - 'Repairing things'

There's a story I think I'll never forget. I was already in bed when I heard a strange noise coming from the kitchen. I rushed there, opened the door and what I saw made me totally shocked. Water was gushing out from the broken faucet.

Of course, it didn't happen unexpectedly. I was bound to happen sooner or later. First of all, the faucet was old. And it should have been replaced, but we were always too busy to deal with it. And we kept putting it off. What's more, we just ignored the harbingers of the impending disaster. For example, a few days before this happened I noticed the faucet was dripping. I told my husband about it, but he said there was absolutely nothing to worry.

A few days later it became apparent that there was something to worry about. The worst thing was that it was almost midnight. So there was very little chance that we would find a 24-hour emergency plumbing repair service. In any case, we had to deal with the problem urgently. What we did immediately was turn off water at the main shutoff valve, which is at the water meter. Thank God, it didn't take us much time to find it. That's all we could do ourselves. The next morning I contracted a local plumbing repair service and scheduled a service call for plumbing repair because fixing is not husband's forte.

It was a nightmare, but I was feeling happy because we didn't flood our neighbors.

Topic 16: Something you can't live without (topic for all test dates till 31 Prev | Next August 2022)

Describe something you can't live without (not a computer or phone) You

should say: what it is how you use it how often you use it

how it helps you and why you can't live without it

Part 3 - 'New and old things'

What I can't imagine my life without now is a vacuum cleaner. I use it every single day, sometimes even twice a day. I'm not obsessed with cleanliness (though my husband says I am a clean freak), but I hate to see dust, crumbs, cat's hair and other particles on the floor, on carpets and on the furniture. I love my cat, but he sheds a ton of hair everywhere every day. It seems to me he drops more fur than one would think is possible. And I've got a chair that gets particularly covered in hair every day 'cause this is the place where my cat likes to chill. If I didn't vacuum every evening, there would be clumps of hair all over our clothes and everywhere. Plus, I like to walk around my flat barefoot, but I hate when my feet get dirty and when dirt and other particles stick to my feet.

I'm happy that I have a really powerful vacuum cleaner which is specially designed for people who keep pets. It's a canister model which has the motor and dust collector, and the vacuum head connected to its main part by a flexible hose. It is a wheeled type and it has really high suction power, so I don't have to put too much effort in order to clean all the surfaces. It's compact and lightweight, therefore I don't have any difficulty using it.

So every evening I vacuum all the surfaces using different heads for different tasks. And I do it even if I feel drained after a hard working day. If it weren't for this vacuum cleaner, the whole flat would be covered in cat's hair, crumbs, dust, torn paper pieces and other particles, which would really annoy me.

Without exaggeration, I'm really happy that humanity once created this household device because it saves a lot of my time, and I clean the whole flat relatively fast.

Topic 17: Person you met once and want to know more about (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a person you met only once and you want to know more about You should say:

who this person is how you met this person when you met this person why you want to know more about this person

Last summer I decided to take a 5-day personal development course. I knew this would help me not only to improve myself, but also to meet like-minded people and form lifelong friendships with them. So, as I expected to have a chance to network with lots of such people. But one of them seemed to be particularly interesting to me. This was a young lady named Helen.

At the very beginning each of us presented a short story in order to introduce ourselves to other group members. She said she was there because she was keen on Psychology. Also, from what other people knew about her I found out she was a successful businesswoman who owned an online store which sold unusual handmade gifts all over the world. During breaks between lectures she always disappeared and I didn't have an opportunity to talk to her in a relaxed atmosphere. I was really surprised to find out that during these breaks she always went to feed her newborn baby who was looked after by her mother while she was studying.

I wish I'd had an opportunity to get to know her. And I still want to get in touch with her in order to know more. I'd like to find out how she manages to take care of her husband and children, always look impeccable, and run a successful business. Another thing I want to know is what makes her so energetic. I'd like to communicate with her to be like her because I really like that she always looks on the bright side of life and she has qualities that are in short supply nowadays.

Those who know her well say she is industrious, ambitious, si minded, knowledgeable, caring and risky. I admire people and want to surround myself with people like her.

Topic 18: Toy (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a toy that you liked when you were a child You should say:

what the toy was who
gave it to you how you
used this to explain
how you felt when you got this toy

Part 3 - 'Toys, kids and ads'

I was a really spoiled kid, so there were tons of different toys competing for my attention, but my all-time favorite was a teddy bear. When I was about 7, my dad came home with a giant box. When I opened it, I saw a brown bear with a big head and black beady eyes staring at me. I started leaping for joy because this toy had been on my wishlist for a long time and I begged my parents for it. It was really cute and cuddly. The whole next day I was really busy choosing the best name for my fluffy furry friend. I'm afraid it wasn't original but I called my teddy Winnie, after my favorite cartoon character Winnie-the-Pooh. It became my best buddy for many years.

Not that I didn't like spending time with my peers, but unlike my friends, Winnie was always by my side, sharing all the moments of my life. I dragged it around everywhere. Once I found out that one eye was missing. I tried to find it, but didn't succeed. I was really upset because I thought it wouldn't have happened if I had looked after Winnie more carefully. So my mom had to get a replacement on the same evening.

Winnie and I spent a lot of time together. I fed it and talked to it. In the evenings I read stories to my teddy bear. When it got sick, I treated it with pretend tea and honey. It is without doubt I took it to bed and it even had its own pillow. Probably it was Winnie that chased away bad dreams. I also taught my bear to read and write, and it was a really assiduous student. Besides, Winnie must have been the most fashionable of all. In the summer it had on some shorts, tee sandals, sunglasses, and a hat. When it was cold and wintry, I would put on a jacket,

sweater, boots, and a cute snowy hat! Winnie is much more than a toy, it is a symbol of my childhood, so it is still with me, hibernating in one of my closets.

Topic 19: Happy event you organized (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a time when you prepared for a happy event

successfully You should say: what the event was when and where it was say whether it was easy or difficult how you prepared

Part 3 - 'Organizing things'

I love different celebrations and parties, but not when I'm the person who is responsible for organizing things. For me, the process of preparation is a chore to be endured. But at least once a year I have to organize my birthday party.

I have a birthday in November. So as you understand, I went through the whole process just a couple of months ago. This time I started preparing a party one month before the date as I didn't want to do everything at the last minute like I usually do.

First of all, I chose a date for the party. Thank God, I didn't need to make sure that most of my friends were free because they know that I always celebrate my birthday on the same day as I was born. It has been for many years, so they don't plan anything. I planned to invite quite a few guests, so obviously I couldn't invite them to my place as my dwelling is : 'one-room flat. For this reason, I booked a table at my favorite restaurant, I ordered food, drinks and a birthday cake. I ordered big colorful balloons and prepared a basket of props handy for people to use to take funny photos. You know, some funny hats and glasses. I discussed a party playlist.

To tell the truth, although it may seem that I didn't do a lot, the process was really tiring. First of all, though || started well in advance, I was pressed for time. Secondly, I didn't want to spend a fortune, so I had to choose everything carefully and compare prices in different places. And sometimes it was difficult for me to make up my mind about some things such as what dishes to choose, what color balloons to order. Such things. But the party was even better than I expected.

Topic 20: Long walk (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe a long walk you had You should say:

where it was
who you were
with why it
was long
how you felt about it

Part 3 - 'Leisure' u

I'm gonna tell you about something that started as a 3hour walking tour and turned into a daylong adventure walk around Z 'cause I got lost. So, several years ago I spent my summer vacation in X. I lived in Y city and almost every day had one-day bus trips to different places.

One day I went to Z city, and had a walking tour of the city. At first, everything was ok. But at some point, the guide started walking faster, and suddenly I realized I had lagged behind the rest of the group.

To my regret, my phone had died, so I could neither call the guide or use Google Maps. Then I asked some passers-by for directions, but they were tourists, just like me. They just shrugged their shoulders and apologized for not being able to help me. I decided to retrace my way, but it appeared to be more difficult than it seemed as there were many winding and narrow streets which looked exactly the same. So I ended up walking round in circles. I had no idea how to get back to the bus. I understood that I would have to take a taxi to return to the hotel. So I stopped worrying about it, relaxed and continued exploring the city on foot. I guess I walked more than 20000 steps on that day. Unfortunately, I wasn't able to document my record 'cause my phone was dead.

Topic 21: Skill you learned from older people (topic for all test dates till Prev | Next 31 August 2022)

Describe a skill that you learned from older people You should say:

what skill it was
who you learned it

from how you did
it
how you feel about it

Part 3 - 'Learning from others'

It is my father who taught me the most important life lessons and skills. And among many things, he taught me to drive safely and confidently.

I went to a driving school. I passed my driving test, but I wasn't a confident driver. So my father decided to teach me to drive like a pro. I liked the idea as I wanted to overcome my fear of driving. But I didn't want to drive a stick. I was going to buy a car with an automatic transmission, so I didn't understand why he wanted me to learn to drive a car with a manual transmission.

We had our driving sessions every weekend. I expected him to break down the process into a series of steps. I thought we would first practice in a simulated environment and focus on mastering one or two functions, say, steering and speed calibration. And I thought he would make me repeat each step until I got it right before leading me headlong into 'real' traffic conditions.

But my father has always been the 'sink or swim' type of a teacher. He took me on X Boulevard, one of the busiest roads in the city. My spine stiffened, my eyes popped and my face turned red like in the episode of 'Tom and Jerry' in which Tom gets his claws smashed by a hammer. I was really scared. Moreover, my father was constantly yelling at me and giving instruction 'n sure that Apollo astronauts received fewer com from mission control than I did from my father. So you can imagine... back in the day when I was 18, I didn't really appreciate the lessons. But his approach to teaching proved to be effective, and I overcame my fear of driving. It was only when I learned to drive a car confidently that I understood what freedom was. Even when I didn't have my own car, I could take my parents' vehicle and go somewhere without waiting for one of them to give me a lift. On many occasions it made getting around the city far more comfortable than it used to be. Now that I have my own car, I think driving is an indispensable skill for me. It saves a lot of time as I don't have to catch the bus, wait for a taxi or ask somebody to give me a lift and completely depend on them. I can stop or change the route any time I want. I'm free to go wherever I need, especially to some places which are difficult to get to by public transport, for example, out of town. What's more, I can take as much stuff with me as I need without keeping an eye on it on a bus. I don't have fingers that are numb after carrying my heavy bags all day round.

Also, I can transport a lot of stuff by hiring special companies. I can say without any exaggeration that since I learned to drive my life has improved in countless ways.

Topic 22: Place in the village you visited (topic for all test dates till 31 Prev | Next August 2022)

Describe a place in the village you visited You should say:

what place it is

when you went

there what you

did there

how you feel about it

Part 3 - 'Countryside'

Last summer I finally visited my grandparents who live in a quiet, picturesque village situated on the bank of the river. During the pandemic, I was trying to stay away from grandparents in order to reduce the risk of infection. I missed them very much. What's more, my grandpa said he was more afraid to die of loneliness than of coronavirus.

So I decided to spend a couple of days in the village and kill two birds with one stone: spend time with my grandparents and get away from the noises and bustle of the city.

My grandparents live in a beautiful, quaint house with a lovely garden all around dotted with blooming orchids. Being there is like traveling back in time. Everything reminds me of my carefree childhood: my toys, o CDs, my bicycle. It feels like you step into another world. All the walls are still covered with old wallpaper. And my grandmother doesn't allow us to remove it. And she refuses to get their house refurbished 'cause she wants to keep all their memories alive. She says they both love their 50-year old chairs and armchairs, their old wooden table in the kitchen, paintings, clay pots, old pictures, lots of things that they bought when they were young.

She's right. There's something special about this old house. It's a magical place. I really love spending time there. So last summer I had a really good time there, as always. In the daytime, I went fishing and just explored the countryside. In the evenings I enjoyed the sunset sitting in the backyard of the house, sipping hot tea

and munching buns with cinnamon baked by my grandmother. I wish I could go there more often.

Topic 23: Thing you did to learn a language (topic for all test dates till 31 Prev | Next August 2022)

Describe a thing you did to learn a language You should say:

what language you learned

what you did how it helped

you

how you felt about it

Part 3 - 'Learning languages'

A few years ago I realized that if I wanted to make further progress in English and sound more like a native English speaker, I would somehow have to gain more exposure to the language native English speakers would use every day. But I couldn't pack up and go to a country where English is spoken natively, so I knew I had to find a way to always get exposed to it at home.

All my friends said I had to subscribe to Netflix and start watching series and TV shows in English. And this is what I did. I remember I started with a TV series which I had already seen in my own language. It was Friends. Who hasn't watched Friends? After that I always found what to watch. First, I watched films and series in English with the subtitles in my own language, so I could check the meaning of any vocabulary I didn't know easily. Later, I had the subtitles in English, and paused if the characters spoke too quickly. When I started feeling more confident, I watched each episode without subtitles. I used the 10 second 'back' button to try again and again to catch all the new words and conversational phrases. Then I played each scene again, and watched the scene with English subtitles on. Then I looked them up and watched the scene again to see how these new words were used in the context. I watched each episode as many times as I needed to the speed, pronunciation, and common expressions used. After that, I always practiced SHADOWING, which I'm sure really helped improve my fluency. I tried to repeat what they were saying at the same time. Again, I used my favorite ten second 'back' button to practice saying and repeating some short phrases a few times.

I believe watching Netflix series and TV shows helped me a lot as I learned the most current version of a language, stuff that may not even exist in textbooks. I learned to speak naturally and easily. And it helps develop my listening skills. What's important is that it was never boring.

Topic 24: Interesting discussion (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

Describe an interesting discussion you had with your friend You should say:

what it was about

what opinions you and your friend had

why it was interesting

how you felt about it

Part 3 - 'Opinions and ideas, communication'

Recently my friend invited me to grab some coffee and catch up. One of the things he told me was that he started thinking of investing his life savings in cryptocurrency. He said it was the best time to invest 'cause the price of bitcoin and several other leading cryptocurrencies had suffered huge falls in December, so the price of bitcoin plunged to about 40000 dollars, but some analysts are predicting the price of bitcoin could hit 100000 dollars by the end of the next year. And there are a lot of new coins that he thinks will make a good investment as well. One more reason why he said cryptocurrency could make a good investment is that everyone says cryptocurrency is the future 'currency of the internet' and ultimate store of wealth. What's more, transactions are fast, digital, secure and worldwide, which allows the maintenance of records without risk of data being pirated.

Despite all this, it was obvious he couldn't make up his mind. I'm sure what I told him didn't help him at all 'cause my knowledge of cryptocurrency is limited. All I could tell him was a couple of stories of bitcoin millionaires and losses. For instance, I told him a sad story of some guy who accidentally threw away 7500 bitcoins when he got rid of an old laptop hard drive. He bought them when they were worth 1 dollar. And they are worth over 200 million dollars today. He now wants to dig up his local rubbish tip, hoping to find the drive. Also, I told him that if I were him, I wouldn't invest more than I can afford to lose, and that I wouldn't invest all my life savings. In my opinion, the discussion was really fruitful as it helped me form a balanced opinion on this matter. And now I'm planning to invest a small amount of money in bitcoin in the near future. But it seems to me my friend began to doubt even more.

Topic 25: Ambition you haven't achieved (topic for all test dates till 31 Prev | Next August 2022)

Describe an ambition you haven't achieved You should

say: what it is

why you haven't achieved it

what you did

how you felt about it

Part 3 - 'Ambitions'

Four years ago I was dreaming of setting up my own business - something that I could do while working my daily job. I decided to use the dropshipping model. It's an online business model in which you don't keep the products you sell in stock. When you sell a product, a manufacturer, wholesaler, or another retailer ships the product directly to a customer.

So for me, it was the easiest way to start my own business. I was told I wouldn't have to stock products, order inventory in bulk, or physically fulfill the orders in any way. But I had to have some capital to launch a website and invest at least a small amount of money in advertising. However, the most important thing was to decide which product to sell. And this is what became my big problem. I couldn't decide what to sell for too long. I spent a lion's share of time on doing market research to figure out what products or services would be in high demand. And when I was about to start acting, there was an outbreak of coronavirus. Obviously, it wasn't the best time to start a business. So I decided to put my plans on hold.

Of course, I felt down for a while, but then I remembered that there's always a second chance. And I'll try again later.

PART 3

Topic 1: Remembering things (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What can people do to help themselves remember information for their everyday needs?

Well, I guess the first thing people should do for this is have the right nutrition, consistent exercise and high quality sleep as they are the basis for strong memory. One more thing I'd recommend them to do is leverage their visual memory or relate new information to things they already know. It could also be a good idea to structure and organize the information people need to memorize or, let's say, create a mental memory tree or to-do list in an app or on paper and, of course, focus their attention on what they need to remember in their everyday life actively recalling these things again and again. I think that taken together, these actions will help everyone preserve their memory strength and remember everything they need for daily use.

2. What do you think of people using calendars to remind themselves of things?

Oh, I think that they are very responsible and disciplined, first of all. Also, I think that they know their goals and like to be sure that they are staying on track with them. One more thing I can say about them is that they don't like to waste their time, and use calendars in order to produce quality work without taking unnecessary, unfocused and inefficient steps.

3. What kinds of things do people forget easily?

Oh, I guess people usually easily forget some simple things like other people's names, phone numbers or birthdays. I'd also add passwords to different websites, words to songs, recipes and doctor appointments to this list. Some other common things which usually literally slip people's minds are what time the meeting starts, where they left their wallet or keys, where they parked or what they wanted to ask and, of course, something they wanted or needed to do like for example, return a call to their partner or friend, reply to some email, pay their monthly bills, book a

ticket in advance and even charge their phone. These are the most common things, I guess.

4. How can people improve their memory?

Oh, there are many fun, simple and even, I'd say, delicious ways to improve memory. First of all, it's necessary to eat a brain-boosting diet because the brain needs fuel just as much as the body does. What is considered healthy for the brain is lots of fruits and vegetables, whole grains, lean protein and healthy fats such as olive oil, nuts, fish and fish oil supplements. For brain health, though, it's not just what we eat but also what we don't eat matters. So, in order to boost brain power and memory we should eat less added sugar and cut down on refined carbs such as cakes, cereal, cookies and white bread. Secondly, in order to help our brain and memory stay sharp we should exercise more as physical activity increases oxygen to the brain and reduces the risk for disorders that lead to memory loss. One more important thing for improving memory is playing different brain games like crosswords, word-recall games and even mobile app games dedicated to memory training, as memory, like muscular strength, requires us to use it or lose it. And, of course, we should consider such things as getting enough sleep, taking breaks throughout the day, using different tricks such as visualization while memorizing something and setting a healthy balance between leisure time as only a combination of all these methods can give us really good results.

5. Why do sometimes people forget things they don't want to do?

I guess this happens because our brain subconsciously erases everything that is likely to bring negative emotions and experiences making room for more positive feelings which accompany actions and events people look forward to. Or there can be even a simpler explanation for this... people just block information about what they don't want to do and, as a result, at some point naturally forget it.

6. Which do you think is more important to remember about, a business meeting or a meeting with a friend?

I am more than sure that it's really essential not to forget about a business meeting because not turning up will communicate a plethora of negatives to your partners showing you as an unreliable and untrustworthy person and assuring them that they can't count on you. Of course, it's better not to forget about a meeting with a friend either but still if it happens, it won't be that embarrassing and unprofessional. What's more, a friend will anyway forgive you and this won't change their attitude to you, which is not the case with your partners or boss.

7. Why is it difficult for some people to remember things?

What kinds of people are more forgetful?

Well, I guess it may be so for a score of reasons. If not to consider age-related memory loss and memory impairment illnesses such as Alzheimer's disease but focus on memory problems typical for healthy people, I think that one of the most common reasons for forgetfulness is that people are just absentminded and don't pay close enough attention to the things that happen to them. One more reason I can name is emotional disorders such as stress, anxiety or depression and, as a result, sleep disorders that make people take certain medications which can cause forgetfulness and confusion. What else? Well, this may happen because of some kind of vitamin deficiency. and, of course, because of a lack of storage space in the brain as brains of some people are overloaded with tons of information.

8. In what situations is it important to remember information very well?

Oh, I think there are lots of such situations but I would divide all of them into two main groups. The first group is all kinds of situations in which you need to be accurate just because you have no right to make a mistake. I mean such situations as taking an exam or just being tested on information if you are a student, making a diagnosis if you are a doctor or vet, or navigating a plane if you are a pilot. In all these cases you have to be able to recall all relevant details, especially if you are alone and have no access to anyone or anything. And the second group is all those situations in which you just want to impress other people in order to gain a competitive advantage. For example, when you want to make a more lively and engaging presentation without rummaging through pages of notes, and this way build your reputation as an expert in your field.

9. Which is better for keeping childhood memories, photos or videos?

Well, I'm more than sure that some situations are better suited to photos and others are better captured in motion, so parents can always just shoot both. Though, there is no doubt that videos handily beat photos as they contain more stuff. I mean movement, dialogue, facial expressions, and consequently, more emotional resonance or, in other words, they help people remember what some past moments felt like, sounded like, how frustrated and stressed-out and over-the moon everyone was all at once. I'd also say that videos show the truest moments and tell the stories that feel real, which adds to my explanation why I think that they are better for keeping childhood memories.

10. Can people rely on their memory when recalling events from the past?

Well, I wouldn't say they can as experts say that human memory isn't as consistent as people would like to believe. People are often guilty of changing the facts and adding false details to their memories without even realizing. What's more, each time they remember something, they are reconstructing the event, reassembling it from traces throughout the brain. Oh, and it's also quite common for people to suppress memories that are painful or damaging to self-esteem. To sum up, human memory is adaptive, reshaping itself to accommodate the new situations people find themselves facing, so it's just probably not a good idea to rely on it 100%.

11. Do you think keeping a diary can lead to creating false memories?

Well, I wouldn't say it can, to my mind, diaries, vice versa, reinforce the memory and help people keep their memories alive. They help people organize their thoughts and make them apprehensible, which in turn, lets them make stronger connections with the information and cement the memories in their mind. So, no... keeping a diary definitely can't lead to creating false memories... though, what it can do is boost people's ability to recall information at a later date

12. Why do people remember very little about things that happened to them in early childhood?

Well, I guess it happens because of developmental changes in basic memory processes. Infants and toddlers don't have a fully developed memory, and they are just unable to make stable memories of events. What's more, the brains of young children lack the skills to keep memories for a long time. I am also sure there are some scientific explanations for why the first few years of life are forgettable but, unfortunately, I don't know them. The only thing I can add to my answer is that at some point, somewhere around the age of 5 - 7, the brain supposedly gets rid of unused or ineffective brain connections making room for more advanced brain networks, which explains why our earliest memories date from approximately 5 years of age.

13. What childhood memories do people usually have?

Well, I guess that the most common childhood memories we all have are about our grandparents, how we visited them, how they pampered us and what they taught us to do... I also think we often recall our childhood friends and adventures we had together, I mean sleepovers with friends, playing with them, fighting with them and even jumping in puddles together. And, of course, we often recall our firsts, bests and worsts. I mean our first day at school, first time staying up for New Year's Eve, first pocket money and how we spent it, first time on the plane or train and even first pet we loved to play with. Plus, we often remember the best and worst toy we had, best or worst sandcastle we built and best or worst theme park

we visited when we were kids. Yeah, these are the most common childhood memories we have when we become grown-ups.

14. Do you think technology helps people remember past events?

Well, on the one hand, 'yes' as it is the only way for today's generation to learn about events of the past. What's more, photos and videos help people keep their memories fresh and remember important events much longer. On the other hand, committing almost all memories to technology might hinder human ability to remember and lead to poorer recall of the factual events. Plus, the quality of such memories may be limited when it comes to photos, for example, as they can help people remember what they saw but reduce their memory of what was said. So, it's a debatable issue, to my mind.

15. What memories are most important for people?

Well, I guess all memories that carry powerful emotions such as happiness, fear, disgust, anger or sadness as such memories are usually about something that matters to people. I'd also mention memories of important milestones in life, I mean the day of graduation, first day at work, weddings, kids' births and things like that. And, of course, memories of the events when they were proud of themselves, when they managed to overcome some challenges and obstacles and achieve the goals they set.

16. What memories are most important for people?

Well, I guess all memories that carry powerful emotions such as happiness, fear, disgust, anger or sadness as such memories are usually about something that matters to people. I'd also mention memories of important milestones in life, I mean the day of graduation, first day at work, weddings, kids' births and things like that. And, of course, memories of the events when they were proud of themselves, when they managed to overcome some challenges and obstacles and achieve the goals they set.

17. Is it possible that technology will replace human memory?

Well, a lot of people say that there is a strong possibility that in the near future we will be able to insert memory chips into our brain. Scientists promise that these chips will enable us to have a perfect memory and control the flashbacks we have by buying new memories and deleting unwanted ones. Though, I think it's more than unlikely that such chips will replace human memory as it seems to me that even if they are inserted into the brain one day, they will only be able to enhance our memory but not replace it.

Topic 2: Gifts (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Why is it sometimes difficult to buy a gift for someone?

Well, I guess one of the reasons is that the giver has no idea what to buy to please the giftee, which puts a lot of pressure and makes the process of choosing the gift quite challenging. This may happen either because the giftee doesn't have any wishes or because the giver doesn't know anything about the wishes of the giftee. The second reason why choosing a gift for someone may be quite painful is because the giver and the giftee have no interests in common, which makes the giftee really hard to please and the giver really anxious about choosing the right present. I also can't help mentioning the time factor as it's really time-consuming to find a great present, and regrettably, nowadays many people are pressed for time. Also, the budget of the giver may be too tight for buying what the giftee would be happy to receive, which also makes the process of choosing the right gift more complicated. These are the main reasons, I guess.

2. Is the price of a gift important?

Will people feel happy when receiving an expensive gift? (frequently asked)

Well, I wouldn't say it is. At least, it seems to me that most people are not concerned with the monetary value of a gift. For the majority of people, the gift is simply a thoughtful gesture, and it is inherent symbolism or emotional significance that matters while whether the gift is cheap or expensive is often secondary. Though, I think there are cases when the price of a gift is of the utmost importance. I mean holidays when people exchange gifts with each other. On this occasion, there should be some kind of implicit agreement for a budget according to which everyone should try to give a gift. To my mind, it will prevent people from conflicts and negative emotions as everyone will know that they have given gifts equal in value to the gifts received.

3. What gifts are popular in your country?

Well, I guess it depends on the age and gender of the receiver, first of all. If the receiver is a woman, then quite popular gifts in my country are arts, I mean drawings, paintings, photographs and prints, or home decor items, for example, candles, vases, figurines and even home fragrances. I'd also mention wines, gift food baskets and accessories such as scarves, umbrellas, wallets or gloves. If the receiver is a man, the most popular gifts are electronics items, for example, smart watches, video games or wireless earbuds. I'd also add such gifts as desktop items. I mean pen clips or holders, pencil sharpeners or ashtrays. It's also quite popular to

give men strong spirits, glassware and accessories such as belts, keyrings and wallets. Oh, and good books, of course, too. If the giver and the receiver have close relationships, the list of popular gifts can also include perfumes, makeup and skincare products, jewelry, kitchen appliances and even spa gift certificates. That's how it's going in my country these days.

4. Do you like giving gifts?

Why do people give gifts?

Oh, yes, I really enjoy gift-giving because it is a perfect way to strengthen bonds with others showing interest and appreciation, expressing gratitude or apology and just letting other people know that I care. I like to bring joy and pleasure to people raising a smile on their faces and fulfilling their small dreams. Even a little present can cheer a person up because it is love and care that matter but not the present itself.

5. Do you think parents are made to give too many gifts nowadays?

Well, regrettably, they really are as children make excessive demands on them for the products they see in the ads, which in turn happens because of advertisers who create a particular state of mind in kids that makes them receptive and pushes to pester their parents for more and more gifts. One more thing that makes parents buy stuff for kids again and again is the fact that they don't want their children to be bullied at school for not having the latest 'must-have' items or don't want to disappoint kids for whom being under peer pressure is quite stressful. Well, and I'd also like to mention the pang of guilt which acts as a driving force for buying as many gifts for kids as possible. Parents have to work a lot these days and as a result, a lot of them feel guilty for this, so guilty that they are ready to succumb to their children's demand for gifts in order to just feel a little bit better.

6. Is it better to give practical gifts?

Well I'd say it is as most people hate receiving useless, generic gifts, giving their preference to presents with a purpose especially if the giver knows them and their current needs and desires well and can afford to give them what they really long for at the moment. As far as the giver is concerned, practical gifts are also much better than fun gifts as they are a great way for the giver to communicate their thoughtfulness to the recipient letting them know that they are aware of what is happening in their life and showing them that they want to make them feel special rather than annoyed or resentful.

7. Is gift-giving important for the economy of a country?

Definitely. The thing is that consumer spending drives much of the economy. (70 per cent, as far as I know) And a large proportion of annual sales in the retailing industry comes from gifts because all, or almost all, people and companies set aside some money each month for buying gifts. I mean people regularly buy gifts for many occasions throughout the year, including holidays such as Christmas, New Year or Saint Valentine's Day, weddings, birthdays, anniversaries, graduations and baby showers. What's more, many people allocate a GREAT proportion of their budget to gifts as they feel pressured to spend more than they are comfortable with during the holidays 'cause they think the more expensive the gift, the stronger a gift-recipient's feelings of appreciation. That people buy gifts so often also means that there are lots of people and companies involved in producing.. distributing, and selling the goods that usually serve as gifts. So, yes, I believe that gift-giving does oil the wheels of the economy by generating sales and creating jobs.

7. What gifts would parents give to children?

Well, I guess it, first of all, depends on the gender of a child and their preferences and needs. As far as I know, boys adore gadgets like smartphones and tablets, tech toys like different kinds of robots and, of course, radio controlled toys which are a great deal of fun to play with. They also enjoy getting toy cars, building and construction sets, different ride-ons and board games as presents. However, girls give more preference to something more creative and intimate like arts and crafts kits, collectibles, dolls and plush toys as well as something emphasizing their femininity like clothes, accessories and beauty_gift sets. So, I guess parents would choose something from the list of gifts mentioned.

8. Why do companies give free gifts to customers?

Well, I guess companies give things away for free in order to have greater customer retention and obtain repeat business. Free gifts generate buzz around the brand and make recipients feel good and satisfied, which causes them to come back and buy from the company. What's more, freebies attract attention and find new customers, which develops positive brand associations and encourages impulse purchases. All in all, companies give free gifts to shoppers in order to encourage feedback and make customers loyal to them as this will garner traffic, boost sales and increase their profits, as a result.

9. Have you ever received anything that was made by the giver?

When receiving a gift, do you prefer something that was self-made or something bought in stores?

Well, yes, I have. Plenty of times, actually. I received such things as homemade candles, soap and body scrub from one of my good friends, different New Year crafts and paintings from my little sister and homemade cakes, marmalade and ginger breads from my neighbors. I really appreciated all those gifts as all of them had a personalized touch, showed more love and created a lasting impression.

Topic 3: Stories (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What kind of stories do children like to listen to?

Oh, I guess all kids like to listen to stories about heroes and villains, giants, dragons and other animals and, of course, about other planets and other children, especially if the children in these stories are powerful. Kids enjoy stories that can bring out courage and laughter, excitement and joy. Oh, and they really like tales with a happy ending, the ones where good triumphs over bad.

2. What can a child learn from a story?

Well, stories can teach kids a lot of things. For example, to understand, accept and express their own feelings, think about and understand other people's motivations as well as predict their thoughts and behavior. Listening to stories, kids can also learn about everyday tasks such as how to brush their teeth, take care of animals, clean and cook, and even learn how to deal with real life situations that they need help to deal with. There are stories which can help children understand where they fit into the world and the ones which can teach them the importance of sharing and compassion with others.

Topic 4: New places (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. How do young and old people react differently to new things?

Well, I guess that new things can cause a significant amount of stress in later life, which makes older adults do their best to avoid novelty. There is good evidence that older people have less motivation to explore new ways of living. They tend to be lower in the personality trait of sensation seeking, and also less open to new experiences. I'm more than sure that it's connected with the fact that new things may cause them to feel uneasy. What's more, older adults are slower in learning. to adapt and, as a result, are slower at responding to changes in their life in comparison with younger people who are fast at responding and more eager to take steps into the unknown, which makes them feel excited whenever life brings new beginnings and adventures to their daily routine.

2. How do young children react when they go to school for the first time?

Well, it's beyond argument that going to school for the first time is a big event for children which always makes kids go through a wide range of emotions, but what they feel and how they react when they go to school for the first time is very much different, depending on whether they have been in childcare before. If they have, I'm more than sure that on the first day at school kids feel excited to see their classroom, meet their teacher and make new friends as most kids really love experiencing new things. Though, if they haven't, I assume that entering a new environment can be scary for young kids and, as a result, often comes with lots of crying, uncertainty and heel digging because it may take them some time to sort out their place among others and start feeling more confident and relaxed.

Topic 3: Rules (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What are some rules that exist in schools or workplaces in your country?

Well, there are quite a lot of them, actually, and they usually differ from school to school and from company to company. The most common school rules that exist in my country are connected with getting to school on time, being respectful to school property, teachers and other students, and keeping the school environment and the local community free from litter. As far as workplace rules are concerned, they are mostly about being punctual, trustworthy, flexible and open-minded, keeping the desk organized instead of spreading out into space that isn't yours, keeping the noise level to a minimum especially in open-plan offices, and being considerate with files and equipment you share.

2. What are some examples of rules that exist in many families?

What rules should children follow at home?

Oh, that's a tough question. I guess the most widespread family rules include telling the truth to each other even when it's not pleasant, looking for ways to be kind and helpful to each other, respecting each other's property and not going to bed in an argument. I also think each family has a set of rules about what they think should be done at home, for example, taking their shoes off in the house, always locking the door when they leave, and putting plates in the dishwasher after eating. and turning out the lights when they are not using a room. These are the most common rules that exist in families I know.

3. What can teachers do to make students obey rules?

Well, there is one thing teachers can do to encourage their students to follow rules. And it's something that at first glance seems obvious, but many teachers fail to do.

What I mean is teachers can explain to their students WHY their rules exist. Dr. Robert Cialdini, an expert in the field of influence and persuasion, describes a well-known experiment that demonstrates that when we ask someone to do or not to do something, the response is more favorable when we give them a reason. So simply adding the word 'because' makes people more likely to do what someone wants them to do. Moreover, teachers can explain how their rules are in place to their students' benefit, especially if teachers say that their priority is to protect their students' right to learn and enjoy school. I think it can transform students' attitude toward the boundaries a teacher establishes for their class. What teachers should definitely not do is use the 'it's either my way or the highway' strategy. Such an authoritarian approach to establishing school rules may cause dislike, rebelliousness, and a desire to misbehave behind a teacher's back. Another thing teachers can do is allow students to participate in developing the classroom rules or behavior guidelines. Giving students a say will allow them to feel valued. As students contribute to the classroom expectations, they are more likely to follow them. And, of course, teachers create compelling lessons 'cause when students are in a class they're naturally inclined to follow rules

4. Do you think the students themselves should have a say in what school rules to have? Oh, I am more than sure they should as having a say on school rules will make children feel more valued and, as a result, increase the bond between them and the school. What's more, I think it will make students more willing to accept changes, which will, no doubt, have a positive impact on their learning and behavior. Though, in some cases it can undermine the power of adults and fuel bad behavior among children, so it's necessary to be careful while engaging kids in making rules and changes to them but still, it's worth trying as the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

5. Why do some people refuse to abide by rules?

Well, I think there can be different reasons why people don't follow the rules they have to follow. One of the reasons I can think of is that they feel that these rules are unnecessary, silly or inconvenient for them, or they think that these rules restrict their freedom somehow. Another reason why people see it as acceptable to refuse to abide by rules is that they know there will be no consequences for not abiding by them. All in all, refusing to follow the rules, people protest against these rules or, on a global scale, rebel against the system they disagree with.

Topic 4: Cities, countryside, tourism (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Is it good for elderly people to live in large cities?

Do most elderly people live in cities?

Probably 'yes' 'cause living in a large city the elderly will have good access to medical services and special deals, to say the least. Also, they will always have a way to get around using public transport, which is really important, as the older people become, the fewer of them continue driving. In big cities retirees will have more opportunities for cultural enrichment and more fitness options that will serve as motivation and social opportunities while improving their physical and mental health. Though, there can definitely be not only advantages but also disadvantages of living in a megapolis such as high crime rates, high noise levels, high prices and many risks connected with the fast pace of life such as troubles with crossing busy streets, for example.

2. Do you think youngsters living in the countryside want to go to live in the city?

Well, I would say it depends on the youngsters and their ambitions and goals in life. If they enjoy privacy and tranquility as well as the slow pace of the countryside and don't feel trapped or limited in opportunities, of course, they try to get the most without moving to the city. But if they dream about more opportunities, I am more than sure they look for ways to live in the city. The city appeals to young people so much because it lets them get a good education and develop their knowledge and skills and, as a result, increase the chances to find employment in good companies. What's more, it provides the youth with limitless sources of entertainment, which is important for breaking away from everyday humdrum activity and enjoying a refreshing moment with close people.

3. Do you think mass tourism returns little benefit to local communities?

I'm afraid it does. It's a well-known fact that mass tourism puts enormous pressure on an area and leads to a variety of problems such as natural habitat loss, increased air and noise pollution, soil erosion, depletion of local resources and even climate change. What's more, it often puts a strain on water resources as the tourism industry generally overuses water resources for hotels, swimming pools and personal use of water by tourists. One more major problem tourists bring is solid waste and littering, as they degrade the physical appearance of the area and sometimes even cause deaths of some living beings, which is horrible. And the money tourists spend during their holidays, unfortunately, cannot compensate for the damage they cause.

4. What advantages can tourism bring to a city?

I guess the main reason is that international tourism is vital for the success of a city's economy as well as its brand value, image and identity. Tourism always boosts the revenue of the economy, helps cities protect their cultural sites, creates thousands of jobs and develops the infrastructure of a city leading to new roads and highways, developed parks, improved public spaces, new airports and even possibly better schools and hospitals. What's more, international tourism plants a sense of cultural exchange between foreigners and citizens as when foreign tourists come to exhibitions, conferences and other types of events, they bring diversity and cultural enrichment to the hosting city. To sum up, tourism contributes towards complete growth and development of a city, which explains the attempts of countries and particular cities to attract a big number of foreign tourists.

Topic 5: Leisure (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. In general, who do you think has more leisure time, men or women?

Well, I wouldn't say there're big gender differences in what concerns leisure time. To my mind, both men and women can have either enough or not enough time for rest depending on their lifestyle and priorities. Though if you consider families where both mothers and fathers work, it's dads who have more leisure time 'cause they work as much as moms but spend much less time on bringing up children and household work.

2. Do you think that people today have more leisure time than people in the past?

Definitely not, to my regret. The world is changing too fast and people have to work more and never stop learning something new to keep up with its pace. Life is getting more and more competitive and in order to survive and be successful people sacrifice a part of their leisure time spending it on developing new skills and fulfilling their potential. As a result, they work unlimited hours in contrast with people in the past who worked from 9am till 6pm spending the rest of their time on family and relaxation.

3. What is the difference in the way people spend their free time nowadays and 20 or 30 years ago?

Well, I think 2 or 3 decades ago people spent most of their time outdoors either playing sports or working in the garden. They also did a lot of household chores, received guests and paid visits to relatives, friends and neighbors. Nowadays people spend most of their spare time surfing the net, playing computer games and communicating with others on social networks. They take a lot of extra classes, exercise, devote time to hobbies and travel around their countries and abroad.

4. What do people in your country do in their spare time?

Oh, nowadays a lot of people living in my country exercise after work and on weekends. I guess it's because more and more people understand that physical exercise is important for both physical and mental health as it gives a release after a day or week of stress. Many people devote quite a lot of their free time to reading and taking extra classes, never stopping learning new aspects of the world around them. Also, they spend plenty of time on their hobbies which are a kind of a breath of fresh air that keeps them grounded and in some cases even offers networking opportunities and, of course, spend time with family and friends, surf the net, entertain and travel as much as they can afford.

5. Is leisure time important for everyone? I believe it's not just important, but essential to have enough rest because we aren't robots and our brain and body cannot work nonstop maintaining the same levels of productivity. If you don't get enough rest, the only likely outcome is a burnout. So weekends serve as a so-called system reboot after which you will feel rested and energetic and therefore satisfied with your life.

6. What types of outdoor activities are popular in your country?

Well, people in my country are keen on beach and sea activities like scuba diving and swimming. A lot of people also like family activities such as picnicking and visiting amusement parks and, of course, mountain activities like skiing in winter or mountain biking in spring and summer.

7. Which do you think are better, indoor or outdoor games?

Outdoor games, for sure. First of all, because they are much more active than indoor games and, as a result, provide aerobic exercise and strengthen the immune system. Secondly, they help children reduce their stress and positively impact anxiety. One more thing they do is provide intellectual stimulation, encouraging, learning and problem-solving skills, promoting creativity and teaching kids to overcome challenges not only on the playground but also in a classroom setting. So, I am definitely all for outdoor games.

Topic 6: Clothes (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do you think students need to wear school uniforms?

I would definitely say, yes, because there are really a lot of pros for wearing school uniforms. The most important of them, to my mind, is the fact that students feel more work-related and identify themselves as a part of some community when they have school uniforms on. As a result, it builds up a sense of school spirit and develops a stronger team morale among students. Moreover, students are free to concentrate on lessons rather than on fashion in the classroom at the same time relieving parents from the necessity to buy clothes for everyday wear.

2. Why do some people like to wear traditional clothes?

Why do people from different countries wear different traditional clothes?

I think it's, first of all, because traditional outfits are wonderful fashion statements of individuality and world experience which help people show their affinity for the local and indigenous people and, of course, play an important role in the preservation of national values and cultural heritage. And the second reason why some people opt for folk costumes, to my mind, is the fact that such clothes are generally made from natural fibers, which makes them comfortable, easy to care for and eco-friendly.

3. What kinds of clothes should people wear at work?

Do you think people should wear formal clothes in the workplace?

I guess it depends on the position they hold and the company they work for. In some companies employees are allowed to dress freely or casually for comfort, which mostly works in a creative work environment. However, companies in which employees continuously deal with clients and business partners, as a rule, need a dress code to maintain a work-related image. If a person holds a top-level position, they should wear so-called boardroom attire. It is a tailored suit in a solid neutral color with a white collared button-up shirt and a modest tie and closed-toe oxfords for men and a perfect fit pantsuit or skirt suit in a conservative neutral color with a white collared button-up shirt, conservative accessories and closed-toe heels in a neutral color for women. A bit less formal, business professional clothing is just the same spick and span and traditional, though a little bit more loose so far as colour or pattern are concerned. The most common dress code is business casual letting employees add spice to their office wear, giving more choice in colour and accessories.

4. Do old people change their style of dressing?

Well, I guess they do as there's no denying that people look different as they get older, which makes them change their clothing choices as they age. I mean that there are various physiological and biological changes occurring during senescence which have an effect upon the clothing needs and preferences of the elderly. For

example, as far as I know, clothing choices for seniors are mostly determined by functionality and comfort like clothes which are easy to put on and take off, let's say, rather than the ones which look beautiful but make old people feel uncomfortable during the day. So yeah, my answer is 'yes', the older people get, the more changes they have in their style.

5. Does personality affect how people choose what to wear?

Can you say something about a person's character judging by the clothes they wear?

Definitely yes. I am more than sure that the clothes people choose are an influential 'tell' of their personalities as they project the self image people want to display. For example, if people are shy and too afraid to draw attention to themselves, they might wear only neutrals and devoid of accessories and, vice versa, if they have positive thoughts and dynamic personality, they are more likely to opt for bright coloured clothes.

6. What kinds of clothes do people wear after work?

What clothes do you like?

Well, to my mind, it depends on where people spend this time after work. If they first go to the gym or play tennis and then meet friends for a cup of tea or just to have a chat, they can have jogging suits or warm-ups or any other active casual clothes on. If they plan to have an informal dinner with friends in some upscale restaurant, then girls can put on some blouse or turtleneck, crisp jeans and a fashionable belt as well as flats or mid-heel shoes and men some long-sleeve shirt and dress trousers with a tipped belt and leather loafers. If people go to some event in an art gallery or theater and then to dinner with friends, they should stick to dressy casual attire like a dress or coordinated separates in semi-dressy fabrics for women and a dress or silk sport shirt and dress trousers for men. The shoes should take on a dressier tone both for male and female. If somebody just plans to run errands or go for a massage, they can wear something like cotton pants and a button-down or polo-style shirt with some sneaker-type shoes just to feel comfortable.

7. When should people wear formal clothes?

Well, I guess they should opt for formal clothes when they want to boost self-confidence, promote self respect and draw the right kind of attention. They should also do it when they want to motivate themselves to get things done, achieve more and improve their ability to see the bigger picture and make astute financial decisions. Well, and of course, when dress-code demands it.

- 8. Do people wear formal clothes more often than before?** I think I can say so as more and more people want to be successful and send a message that they are professional. Formal clothes are a great helper in this. They also help people feel powerful and leave a good first impression, which gives them a competitive edge. To my mind, this explains why people wear business clothes more often than before.

Topic 7: Social media (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What do people do on social media?

What are the advantages and disadvantages of social media?

Well, both individuals and businesses can benefit from using social media in numerous ways. And there are some disadvantages as well. So, first of all, using social media, people never feel alone. They keep updated on the activities of their friends, relatives, acquaintances and celebrities they admire as well as make new friends all over the world. They can communicate with relatives and friends, read interesting articles, stay up-to-date with news and current events, find funny or entertaining content. People can share opinions, get and give help. However, some people base their self-worth on social media likes, which is not healthy. There are also people who post something on Facebook and then literally just sit there and watch whether they get 100 likes on their picture. And what is sad is that their self-worth is based on how they are accepted, wanted, and desired by social media. Another disadvantage is that people now are so used to communicating via social media networking sites that they're forgetting how to make friends in real life. Also, I can't help mention the fact that threats, intimidation messages and r.u.s can be sent to the masses to create discomfort and chaos in the society as anyone can create a fake account and do anything without being traced. A Y that's scary.

2. What kind of things are popular on social media?

Well, I think that live streams are really popular on social media nowadays, maybe because they are dynamic and really engaging. They turn a video from a broadcast into a conversation as they let people share comments and likes that the live streamer can respond to in real time, which builds trust and allows those who go live to keep the content top-notch moment to moment. One more really popular thing on social media these days is questions and polls as they are excellent tools for engaging interaction from the audience. Also, I can't help mentioning posts with useful information as they are more popular now than ever before and

encourage comments, shares and saves. What else? Well, there are two more things I'd like to name. Number one is long-form IGTV content as videos that are more than a minute long provide people with more opportunities to build relationships and connections with their community. And number two is gamified content such as quizzes and bingo as they add some fun to people's pages and, as a result, increase engagement significantly.

3. Is it easy to find real friends on a social networking website?

Well, I'd say it is as it is common interests and passions that bring people together. So it doesn't really matter where one makes friends. Though, we should always remember that it's quite easy to find real friends but takes a lot of work to keep them.

4. What kind of people do you like to be friends with on those websites?

Well, I always send friend requests to people who inspire me to better myself, who have a great experience in my industry or people with insights to impart. I really like being friends with them because they pull me out of my shell and introduce new ideas, philosophies and activities spurring me into action and making me grow.

I really like to be friends with people whose views oppose mine. They are my teachers who push me to break out of my comfort zone and help open my eyes to different worldviews, learning to accept people who don't see the world the way I see it.

5. What kind of social networking websites do you like to use?

Well, I mostly opt for professional networks such as LinkedIn and Xing. 'Cause they are a good assistant in my business issues such as meeting customers, recruiting new employees, keeping up with the latest news in business and developing relationships with suppliers and colleagues. I really like Facebook 'cause it lets me make social connections, stay in touch with what friends are doing.. share photos or videos with others and just fill up my free time whenever I have it.

6. Learning from others (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

What kinds of things can young people learn from old people?

To my mind, old people can teach the young lots of things starting from different necessary skills to attitude to themselves, people around them and life. But I guess that the most important lessons they can teach young people are to stay positive in

any situation and remember that there is always a way to make a difference and change life, to never let the learning stop, remembering that wisdom is something they acquire over ages but not something they are born with, to appreciate blessings in life, to be grateful for what they have, to take care of health and, of course, to value their bonds and people they included in their life.

7. How can people in the neighborhood help the elderly during the epidemic?

Well, I guess they can do it in a number of ways, actually. For example, they can set up or join a WhatsApp group for the community to keep in touch to ensure the elderly feel connected to someone as many older people may be alone during the epidemic. Secondly, they can check whether any local community groups or charities are coordinating to provide services for the elderly, sick or vulnerable and contact them to see if they can help or donate. Well, and of course, they can help their old neighbors in person offering them to go shopping for groceries or pick up medicines, take down the trash, take the dog for a walk or pets to the vet if the owner can't get out, and simply call their neighbors to chat to let them feel less stressed and anxious.

Topic 8: Countryside (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Is it possible that all of the population will move to cities?

Will people live in the countryside in the future?

Well, undoubtedly, there will be more and more people moving to cities because of educational opportunities (as everyone knows that all major and affluent colleges and universities are located in or near big cities) and because of a better job market. Also, I think that cities will attract more and more people with their better medical care and even the lifestyle because collective cultures create an exciting cultural backdrop. However, massive population growth will inevitably lead to more pollution, higher accommodation costs, congestion and a number of other problems. So, I'm sure that at some point the trend will be reversed. What's more, there will always be different types of people: those who strive for achievements and those who opt for peace, a slow pace of life, pure privacy and utter tranquility. Thus, there will always be people who will stay in the countryside. So, I don't think that all of the population will ever move to cities.

2. Would you like to live in the countryside in the future?

Oh no! Not until I retire! I'm only 25 and dreaming of a high-flying career, but I'm afraid that living in the countryside will leave my career in tatters. Besides, I'm a very active and sociable person, so I think I will be bored to death being deprived of an active social life and abundance of entertainment options a big city provides.

Well, this isn't what I'm dreaming of. I'd rather say! don't mind swapping city life for a rural idyll. I'm tired of the constant rat race and I'll definitely enjoy a slower pace of life. Also, I want to live in a house with multiple rooms, a garage and swimming pool which is obviously not possible until I move out of the city.

3. What is the difference between living in the countryside and the city?

I guess that the most striking difference is that in the countryside there isn't much traffic even during rush hours. Again, as there are fewer vehicles emitting exhaust fumes, rural areas are nowhere near as polluted as urban ones. So the air is definitely fresher. This is why it's highly likely that people living in the country live longer. However, there may be many people who won't appreciate these benefits as there aren't many opportunities for professional growth and the choice of facilities is limited.

4. Do you think youngsters living in the countryside want to go to live in the city?

Well, I would say it depends on the youngsters and their ambitions and goals in life. If they enjoy privacy and tranquility as well as the slow pace of the countryside and don't feel trapped or limited in opportunities, of course, they try to get the most without moving to the city. But if they dream about more opportunities, I am more than sure they look for ways to live in the city. The city appeals to young people so much because it lets them get a good education and develop their knowledge and skills and, as a result, increase the chances to find employment in good companies. What's more, it provides the youth with limitless sources of entertainment, which is important for breaking away from everyday humdrum activity and enjoying a refreshing moment with close people.

5. What do people like to do in the countryside?

There's generally not much to do in the countryside, especially in the winter, so I'm sure the majority of young people like to chat with their friends online or play computer games. They may also like to get together in order to play football, ride bicycles or explore the surroundings. This is because if children are not glued to their devices, they usually have active pastimes. The more adventurous, the better. Again, as the number of recreational facilities is severely limited in the countryside, it seems to me that the most popular activity with adults is having barbeque parties or just chatting with their neighbors over the fence.

Topic 9: Learning languages (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What are the difficulties of learning a new language?

What difficulties do people face when learning a language?

Well, the fear of making mistakes and shyness to speak in a new language, first of all. People don't like to make a fool of themselves, which makes them embarrassed to practise and speak in a language they are learning as much as possible. One more challenge I can think of is lack of vocabulary or grammar, oh, and of course, lack of time to improve their knowledge of both.

2. Why do people learn foreign languages?

Oh, I think they mainly do it in order to open up a world of job opportunities and completely transform their travel experience, having a chance to communicate with people from all over the world without any barriers. I also know people who learn other languages to increase their brain power as language learning has a number of positive effects such as memory improvement and a reduced risk of age-related cognitive decline. Young people usually start learning languages for meeting new people and establishing deep cross-cultural friendships, and often end up doing it for studying or living overseas. I guess these are the main reasons.

3. What can people do to learn a second language?

Well, they can use as many ways of getting immersed in the language as possible. For example, they can hang out with native speakers, watch TV shows and movies with subtitles, read books, blogs, newspapers and magazines or maybe even start their own blog in this language. I'd also recommend people to listen to everything that is comprehensible, interesting and engaging like audiobooks, podcasts and interviews with the celebrities. Well, and sign up for a regular language tip too.

4. Is making foreign friends the best way to learn English?

Well, I wouldn't say it's the best way to learn English though it's definitely the best way to conquer people's fear of speaking and making mistakes. I think that learning Grammar is of primary importance as it is the foundation for communication, and I don't think foreign friends can teach grammar the way which will keep people from being misunderstood while expressing their thoughts and ideas. On the other hand, foreign friends are a good motivation to really improve a language in order not to feel hindered in communication. So, it's definitely worth making such friendships to feel as comfortable as possible while conducting talks with native speakers.

5. Some people travel to learn a foreign language, what do you think?

I'll second that! Being in a foreign country where nobody speaks their native language pushes people into the corner and makes them delve into their memory to find necessary words and phrases. It helps them overcome language barriers, giving them a chance to enjoy themselves. communication with native speakers, and developing speaking skills. Practicing everyday speech patterns and hearing particular accents foster language skills and increase people's confidence. That's why the learning process gathers pace and produces the desired results much faster.

6. Is it better to study in a group or individually?

I think studying in a group is much better as, firstly, it is more affordable than one-to-one classes, but at the same time it is not less efficient. Further, there's a competitive spirit that forces everyone to study hard regardless of the circumstances. Even when students are tired they cannot let themselves skip doing homework because they don't want to be worse than their group mates. One more advantage is that group lessons have far more energy than one-to-one classes due to interaction between group members

7. What's the best way to learn a foreign language?

I'm sure that the best way to learn a foreign language is to immerse in it. People can do it even without attending language classes, just by making the most of modern technology. What they can mostly benefit from is changing the operating language of mobile devices into the language they are learning. This will give them a chance to get back to foreign words again and again and expand their vocabulary. There are also a lot of websites providing ground for watching TV shows in a foreign language with subtitles, listening to audiobooks or podcasts, playing games and many other activities in different languages. Also, I believe traveling can do its bit thanks to round-the-clock language immersion, which leaves no chance to avoid communication.

Topic 10: Music (topic for all test dates till 30 April 2022)

1. What kinds of music do you like to listen to?

I am a music lover so I enjoy listening to different kinds of music because any music be it classical, electronic or pop creates some feelings in my soul. Moreover, different kinds of music influence me in different ways, for example classical music lessens depression whereas rock music evokes strong memories.

2. What kinds of music are most popular in your country?

I think people in my country mostly enjoy pop and rock. Pop music appeals to people with its pretty melodies and catchy lyrics while rock is liked simply because it provides soundtracks for life experiences, motivates people and energizes them.

3. Why do many young people spend a lot of money on music concerts?

Why do some people like to listen to live music while others prefer CDs?

Well, I guess the first reason is concerts bring a bit of joy into their everyday lives and let them feel free, swaying to the beat and spending several hours jumping around. What's more, live concerts help people find the inspiration they need and boost their happiness. Taken all together, watching live performances reduces stress and improves people's general sense of well-being. Oh, and one more reason I can think of is that live shows give young people a chance to meet and greet their idols, which provides them with a truly once-in-a-lifetime experience, which each of us values.

4. Do you think music concerts are suitable for old people to attend?

Well, I wouldn't say they are as live concerts, I mean pop and rock concerts, are usually too noisy and quite dangerous for the elderly. When I say quite dangerous I mean that there is a high probability to get squashed or hit in the mosh pit as the stampede always occurs when the show starts. Younger people just can't help themselves from charging to the front and taking up all the space by the stage. They get too engrossed with singing and screaming at their favorite performer and forget about those around them, which can make the whole experience of the old quite strenuous as they will have to focus on fists and elbows flying around rather than on the concert itself. What's more, the fact that it's necessary to stand at most pop and rock concerts and in longer-than-necessary lines before concerts may spoil the experience as well 'cause long standing will most likely cause back pain that will rack their tortured, aged bodies. So, I guess it's better to enjoy the concert in comfort watching it on TV or YouTube rather than get tired after a few hours of noise, queues and standing trying to see what is going on on stage. But if we are talking about a classical music concert, why not

Topic 11: Food (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Is it important to have a meal together with your family?

Well, definitely yes. I would even say family meals are vital for present-day families as they feed each family member not only physically but also emotionally helping, them handle the stresses of daily life and the hassles of day-to-day existence. What's more, they provide children with a sense of security and

togetherness, which has positive effects on child development and selfesteem. One more positive feature of family dinners I can mention is promoting more sensible eating habits as eating together with kids lets parents influence what they eat and provide a model for children to carry with them into adulthood. Oh, I nearly forgot to mention one more advantage - family meals provide the opportunity for conversation letting relatives find out what's going on in each person's life, review the day that's passed and plan for the day that's coming.

2. Do people in your country care about where products are from?

Well, the majority of people in my country do care about what products they buy and where these products are from because they care about what they are putting, into their bodies and want to be sure that the foods they buy are produced without the use of genetic engineering or genetically modified organisms, do not contain toxic pesticides, antibiotics, growth hormones and stuff like that, and have high nutritional value. Though, I am sure that there are also a lot of people in X who don't care about it at all. So, it depends on people and their life priorities.

3. Do you think people are fully responsible for what they eat?

Absolutely. Although some people blame ads to feel resilient about their poor food choices, saying they have little choice but to consume that food because the ads are so pervasive as to make them powerless to avoid the food, I'm convinced that people (I mean adults) have to take full responsibility for what they eat because it has a big impact on our health, and it is people, not food producers or advertisers, that will suffer the consequences of their poor diet. For example, a poor diet that is high in junk food can lead to cardiovascular disease, type 2 diabetes, some types of cancer and even earlier mortality rates. Also, eating highly processed foods, saturated fats and added sugar on a regular basis is linked to many negative health effects. Everyone knows fast food is one of the major culprits of the global obesity epidemic. So eating unhealthy food will inevitably lead to health problems, and people will have no-one but themselves to blame. Also, I'm sure that it's not really other people's occupation to take care of it for someone else. As far as children are concerned, I think that parents are responsible for what their children eat because when a certain age is reached, children don't understand what is good and what is bad for them. I mean if children were given the freedom to decide what to eat, they would eat French fries 3 times per day.

4. Is it important for people to learn about foreign foods?

Well, of course, it's not a matter of life and death, but I think it's important in some situations. For example, it's important for future chefs and for those who are interested in culinary arts. I mean people who love to cook and always try to cook

something new. Also, it would be great for people who identify themselves as foodies. I think they are always in search of interesting tastes and flavors. And I'm sure it's important for travelers, especially for those who have stomach problems from time to time. They need to know what dishes may cause indigestion, so they will know what foods to try and what foods to avoid while traveling. Finally, it's important for people who want to explore certain countries and cultures 'cause each country's cuisine reflects its unique history, lifestyle, values, and beliefs. For example, in China, harmony is a vital trait in almost every aspect of life. This is reflected in Chinese cuisine, where almost every flavor (salty, spicy, sour, sweet, and bitter) is used in a balanced way creating delicious dishes with flavors that go well together. And it may be interesting to find out why people from different parts of the world eat different types of food.

Topic 12: Opinions and ideas, communication (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What jobs need employees to be talkative?

In what industries do you think communication is a necessary skill?

Oh, plenty of them, actually. Teachers, for example, as they talk throughout the day, often repeating the same material to different classes of students, or reporters who conduct plenty of interviews and follow-up interviews with their sources in order to get stories straight. I can also mention jobs of sales representatives who need to be talkative as they spend the majority of their days selling their products or services, customer service representatives who are expected to have all the answers and be able to communicate clearly and human resources specialists who consult with employers to find gaps in employment, interview applicants and organize new employee orientation.

2. When do children begin to have their own ideas and opinions?

Well, I don't think there's any one-size-fits-all magical age when children start to have their own views for life as every child grows and develops differently. As my experience shows, almost every child aged eight years and older is already able to express their views through talking, writing, drawing and other activities. However, I am more than sure that there are kids who start doing it much earlier, let's say, at the age of 4 or 5. So, to my mind, it depends on the child and the environment they grow up in.

3. Do children like to change opinions?

Do children have strong opinions?

Absolutely! Young children form opinions mostly based on their experience. So in early stages of development, children change their opinions over and over again as they learn something new every day. They engage in an ongoing process of hypothesis testing and revision. They are exploring the world day by day and therefore moving from a less to more accurate picture of the world, which inevitably leads to a change in perception of everything around them. As children age, new social influences demand a certain conformity, which makes them see things differently, thereby changing, established opinions.

4. How can teachers help children develop their ideas and opinions?

Well, in a number of ways, actually. For example, by listening to kids' ideas with interest and taking their views into account. Or by organizing different activities which will support kids in expressing their opinions. One more perfect method teachers can use is to involve kids in a decision-making process and share their adult power and responsibility for decision making with them. I want to believe these things will help kids succeed in developing their ideas and opinions.

5. Do you think children will always have ideas and opinions similar to those of their parents?

Well, on the one hand, 'yes' as children are unavoidable. an extension of their parents. I'd even say that kids are like empty cups parents can pour their beliefs and views into, and they are more likely to stick. On the other hand, children are not there to lap up and regurgitate all opinions of their parents, and even if they do get affected by what their parents think, I think this strong parental effect does not last forever.

Topic 13: Jobs (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What kinds of jobs are well-paid in your country?

What jobs do young people prefer?

Well, I think the highest paying jobs in India are jobs in management and investment banking as well as IT and software. Professionals in these spheres are highly sought after by top companies and offered really high salaries because their knowledge and skills have a huge impact on business productivity and performance. The work they do and the decisions they make affect the success of the company and that is the main reason why these jobs pay really well. They are followed by jobs of chartered accountants, oil and natural gas sector professionals, medical employees and aviation staff.

2. What will be the most popular jobs in the future?

Our world never stops evolving. Neither does the world of technology and the sphere of information technology in particular. So I have no doubt that the most popular jobs in the future will be somehow connected with IT. I guess software systems developers, software application developers, computer and information systems managers and IT security specialists will be more than in favor in the future. I am also convinced that other types of technology will continue developing and there will be much tension around the issue of alternative energy sources. engineers will be in demand as well. And one last thing | can suppose that people will appreciate jobs connected with global business and health as well as finance and international law.

3. What are the benefits and disadvantages of working from home?

Well, I think that the main benefit of working from home is a flexible schedule which allows employees to spend more time with loved ones, for example, children or pets, and this way have a better work-life balance. One more advantage of working from home I can think of is a custom work environment which can make employees work more efficiently. What I mean is homelike noise level, cozy clothes and no office distractions like loud discussions of colleagues and, of course, zero commuting, and, as a result, no crowds and traffic. As far as the disadvantages of working from home are concerned, I'd name such things as lack of personal interaction, which often can result in boredom or even loneliness and also difficulties connected with sticking, to a routine and separating home and work life as in many cases they simply slow down task performance and at times even prolong the employee's working day.

4. What are the disadvantages of working flexitime?

Well, I think that the main downside of working flexitime is that it has the potential to complicate every aspect of day-to-day work as there is no clear delineation between work and free time in the flexitime schedule. What I mean is that working flexible hours makes it all too easy to slip into working beyond set hours because it makes it unexpectedly difficult to work with colleagues who work at different times which prevents employees from performing their tasks on time without breaking their work schedule. What is more, I'm more than sure that flexitime work requires a high degree of self-motivation and is a disadvantage for those employees who cannot organize their work efficiently.

Topic 14: Getting along with others (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1 Why do many people nowadays say there aren't enough hours in the day?

/Do people have enough time for themselves?

In my opinion, most people are feeling pressed for time as the society's standards for success are very high these days, which puts people under great pressure. As a result, many people work longer hours, and their work schedules are becoming more and more exhausting. Some people work multiple jobs. All this leaves them with objectively less free time for rest and sleep. Not getting enough rest causes people to perform worse than they ordinarily would, even with the aid of caffeine or other products. And when people perform slower than they otherwise would, it's inevitable that they feel that time is always slipping away. Plus, nowadays people seem unwilling to accept the fact that they can't fit everything in 'cause they don't want to let anyone down, and they can't say no, so most people are now biting off more than they can chew. For example, they try to force work, children, friends, bread baking, jogging, and weekly virtual yoga into their schedules. Many people try layering tasks, such as listening to music or a podcast while organizing their office. Of course, all this leaves people with the sense that they just don't have enough time to get everything done and never have time for themselves.

2 Why do young people like to talk to old people?

They say that you can't know where you are going until you know where you have been. That's why every time young people get a chance to communicate with the old, they take an opportunity to ask a wiser generation about past events. The aged are a unique source of information and advice for young people. Recalling the past, old people can help guide young people toward choices that will be for their benefit and help them avoid making decisions that will destroy them. What's more, they can help the young to learn how and why people lived as they did throughout the world and explained the changes and causes of some changes throughout the course of history. And, finally, discussing the past with the elderly helps a young generation acquire a richer and broader understanding of the world today and their place in it, which helps them succeed in their present and future.

3. How do you get along with people you don't like?

Well, first of all, I try to avoid communication and stay away from someone I don't like. But if I am forced to deal with them, I go above and beyond to stay calm and focus on thinking positively. What helps me most of all to hold my nerve is drawing mental boundaries and keeping my distance. Sometimes I also take pains to pretend that everything is ok and even be nice and friendly but it's only if my disaffection has no substance behind and is based only on my gut instincts.

I always strive to be in tune with other people and I can hardly find somebody I dislike a lot or have strong conflicts with, but even if I do, I recognise that these

disagreements are a result of differences in values so | acknowledge the reality of others and try to look only for the positives in our communication. I also never take things personally and, as a result, have fewer pegs to hang a grievance on. I am convinced that people whom we dislike or have a grudge against are sent to our lives to teach us something, sometimes humility, sometimes just love, this is why I am always on friendly terms with everyone.

Topic 15: Accommodation (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do people in your country mostly buy their own home or do they rent their home? Well, I guess both. Those who have enough money mostly buy accommodation 'cause it's a kind of investment in their future. What's more, home ownership is something that, on the one hand, gives them and their families a sense of stability and security and, on the other hand, provides them with freedom to do whatever they want both inside and outside, dispensing them with the necessity of having humiliating, awkward and frustrating relationships with landlords. But there are also a lot of people who don't have enough money. or want to be more flexible with their lifestyle having a wish to pick up and leave pretty quickly, and they always opt for renting their home considering home ownership an expense.

2. Do most people in your country live in a flat or a house?

What are the benefits of living in a house?

Well, the majority of people live in flats 'cause it usually involves less costs and provides more security as there are a lot of people around. What's more, it is more comfortable to live in flats because they are usually located in the city, so it doesn't take too much time to get to the city center and there are no problems with shopping for basic essentials because of the availability of convenience stores. One more factor which attracts people to living in flats is the fact that flats already have all necessary facilities such as power and water backup, uninterrupted supply of cooking gas and so on. Though there are also quite many people in my country opting for living in houses mainly because houses usually have more living space as well as outside space and provide people with greater degree of freedom.

3. Why do most people in your country live in flats rather than houses?

I guess, first of all, because it's more affordable as living in an apartment involves less costs.

What's more, it's safer because of the close proximity of neighbors who will look after each other's apartments whenever possible. One more factor which can turn

people to choosing a flat instead of a house is lower responsibility as there is a special committee which will solve all types of sanitary-engineering, electricity and other problems which may arise.

4. Do you think the design of a home is important?

Oh yeah, it is. First of all, it plays the key role in the building's functionality. I mean a good design can make even a really small flat or house functional and cozy. Also, being surrounded by comfort and beauty unequivocally makes our daily experiences better and increases our satisfaction not only short but also long term, making us productive and happy. So, no doubt, home design is of great importance.

Topic 16: Free things (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What free gifts do companies usually give to their customers?

Oh, I guess something pleasant and valuable to the customer or, in other words, something that has perceived value. Well, I mean such gifts as books. For example, a relevant book will stick with the customer for a long time, reminding them of the brand. Or this can be an experience like a spa package or tickets to a local event as it's also a great way to make the brand memorable. One more popular gift that companies give to their customers is sweet, customizable, widely-loved treats, for instance, cookies or chocolates which will definitely be appreciated by most customers. Oh, and all kinds of promotional items like T-shirts, shopping bags and even notebooks. On customers' birthdays businesses usually send personalized handwritten notes and flowers. On some occasions, companies can give their customers surprise upgrades and free additional services.

2. Why do companies give free gifts to customers?

Well, I guess companies give things away for free in order to have greater customer retention and obtain repeat business. Free gifts generate buzz around the brand and make recipients feel good and satisfied, which causes them to come back and buy from the company. What's more, freebies attract attention and find new customers, which develops positive brand associations and encourages impulse purchases. All in all, companies give free gifts to shoppers in order to encourage feedback and make customers loyal to them as this will garner traffic, boost sales and increase their profits, as a result.

Topic 17: Repairing things (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Why do people like to get their mobile phones repaired in specialized stores?

I think that, first of all, people opt for getting their cell phones fixed in specialized stores because these stores always offer high-quality solutions and deliver reliable one-time fixes as well as a warranty for their device. Another reason why people do so is because the warranty provided by the company or authorized seller for their phone allows them to get their phone repaired in such stores at no cost. Finally, the majority of people understand that unlike other items they may have in their home, their smartphone is a complicated piece of machinery, which means that they are at risk of further damage and data loss when they resort to fixing the phone themselves. These are the main reasons, to my mind.

2. What kinds of things do people like to repair by themselves?

Well, I guess the ones that are fairly simple repairs or the ones that are not a problem to fix following some simple instructions. I mean such things as broken eyeglasses, zippers or headphones, leaky faucets, running toilets and even sticking doors as it's quite easy to find adequate guidance on how to fix them both online and in user manuals. What's more, these are the things that get broken as often as not, which makes them pretty simple and enjoyable to fix with some experience under the belt.

Topic 18: New and old things (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do you think that keeping old things in a family is a great way to connect with the past?

Why do grown-ups hate to throw away old things?

Oh yeah, it definitely is as family heirlooms bring past generations into the present and preserve family history. and history in general for future generations. Also, they provide insight into the lives of ancestors and a richer understanding of family values, beliefs and traditions. It seems as if they bring family memories to life and this way form a bridge between family_past and family. future. So, there is no doubt that family heirlooms are a perfect way to connect the present and even the future with the past.

2. Which do you think are better, old things or new things?

Old things, to my mind. They have their own story and this is what catches the imagination and fascinates people. Old things also serve as reminders or memories making life more meaningful and letting people feel the stillness of time. They are pieces of history which hold sentimental value for many people as they carry a genuine significance to whole families or even generations. In addition, old things are mainly rare, which makes people, owning them, feel special and keep on sticking to old stuff.

3. Which do you think are better, old things or new things?

New things, definitely. Our brains are made to be attracted to novelty. New things lend a great deal of color to our lives, making us feel good and proud of being the first to own something that nobody else possesses yet. Another reason to opt for new things is that they elicit new emotions and make us feel cool and fashionable. They are usually of a better quality, safer and more efficient. And this is what makes people change old stuff into new from time to time.

4. How do shops attract customers?

Well, nowadays shops try to attract customers by having a strong online presence, regularly updating their social media accounts and store's website. They also appeal to customers by having sales and adding a bit of urgency to their offers, I mean using a strong call to action such as 'Be quick' and 'Buy now'. For making visitors buy when they are already inside the shop, shop managers organize an effective store layout, make customers feel valued and appreciated and offer points or rewards to attract repeat business.

5. Has the way of shopping changed?

Nowadays the majority of people do shopping online. First of all, it's convenient. You don't have to make time, drive all the way to a store and, god forbid, if the items you were in the pursuit of appeared to be unavailable. On the Internet, you can buy whatever you want in a matter of seconds without interrupting other activities. You can do it literally on the go. All you need is to have a payment card and any Internet-enabled device. Further, online shops can offer prices which are hard to beat as costs of their operations are substantially lower than those of traditional ones. Also, it is without doubt there's a much larger selection than any traditional store can possibly keep in stock. Many people like online shopping as it gives them access to products they can't buy locally. I guess in general online shopping has become so popular with people because it's absolutely hassle-free.

Topic 19: Ambitions (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. What kind of ambitions do people usually have?

Well, I guess that the most common ambitions people have nowadays are educational and personal development ambitions as well as career and financial ambitions. I mean such things as university studies, vocational courses and professional qualifications, taking on and mastering new challenges, broadening the mind through travel or reading, learning new skills coupled with starting a small or big business, gaining a particular accolade, getting a promotion and increasing the earning power. I'd also add physical and health ambitions to the list as more and more people start bothering about improving their cardiovascular fitness, losing fat, sculpting their body and making it more agile, flexible and relaxed. And, of course, there are relationships and spiritual ambitions such as finding a life partner, having children, and freeing up the time to do some voluntary work, getting involved in a charitable project overseas, or just meditating regularly.

2. What would you feel if you couldn't achieve your goals?

I think failure to achieve my goals would make me really upset and frustrated and would definitely shake my confidence. But whether I like it or not, it is necessary. stepping stone on the way to success, so I am sure | would relax and calm down and try to find blessing in it. I also hope that instead of feeling sorry for myself i would feel more motivated to find other ways and do my best to achieve my goals this time.

3. Do you think nowadays people have a better work-life balance than in the past?

How do people balance life and work?

I'd say they do as nowadays the world offers so many. different ways to work and study that sacrificing personal life looks more like a mindset than a real problem. A lot of present-day employers do their best to help their employees have a good work-life balance by offering flexible work hours, the ability to work from home, improved overall workplace experience and opportunities for professional growth and social connections. So, even if many people are doing more work these days, it's only because it allows them to earn more money and live their lives to the fullest. What's more, in this day and age, fewer people have false expectations that they can have a lot of free time and earn a lot of money at the same time, which has helped them define what lifestyle they really want to have and enjoy sticking to it, feeling satisfied and happy.

Topic 20: Making friends (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. How and where do people in your country make friends these days?

Well, there are lots of opportunities to strike up a friendship with somebody who will walk through life together with you, sharing all your ups and downs, joys and pains. But, of course, it will take some doing to succeed. First of all, you need to spend more time around people. There are a huge number of different clubs and online communities with people who have common interests, so you can join those that appeal to you and find some mates there. Secondly, when you visit some social, cultural or professional events, always remember about making eyecontact and smiling at people, making small talk with them and maybe even asking those whom you like out for lunch or coffee. You should also get to know your friends' friends and, sure thing, accept invitations to go out whenever you get them.

I guess these days my compatriots make friends in two ways either rubbing shoulders with different people at various events, be it parties, concerts, self-improvement clubs or something else, or joining general interest groups on the Internet and buddying up with others by making comments in forums or under posts in social networks, sharing good content with other members of these groups and later on initiating si get-together to get a chance to communicate face-cuface.

2. What places are popular for meeting friends in your area?

Well, I guess all kinds of places where people can have a pleasant experience together like questrooms, cinemas, live sporting events and restaurants, as well as all those places where friends can have a lot of fun, for instance, amusement parks or karaoke clubs. I also think that quite a lot of friends meet in places where they can walk and do something active together. I mean parks, embankments and even fitness centers. Many girls in my area get together with friends in spa-centers while men usually opt for saunas and baths. In winter time, the most popular places for friend gatherings are skating-rinks and pubs, and in summer time, many friends meet on beaches and in countryside resorts.

3. Would you only make friends with people who are similar to you?

Is it important to have the same interests and hobbies when making friends?

Well, of course, I wouldn't. What I think should be similar is values, all the rest can or even must be different. No two men are alike and it makes life really interesting. Maybe I can feel really comfortable with friends like me because we can do

activities that all of us are interested in and they are more likely to understand my reactions and behavior in some situations 'cause they would have it the same way, but what makes me really learn and grow is differences. Friends with a different background can give me a lot, for instance, knowledge and information about new things I am weak at, a different perspective of the world and even a chance to enjoy different lifestyles. By exchanging our ideas and experience, we can enrich each other and that's the main thing in friendship.

4. Do you like meeting new people?

Oh, I really like it. Every new meeting lets me learn something new and this way opens a whole world of opportunities. It also pushes me to get out of my shell and get new fresh ideas. Oh, and it brings new friendships to my life, so, it's really cool!

5. Do you think old friends are more important to the old generation or to the young generation?

Well, I'd say old friends are more important to the old generation as the elderly don't usually have many work and family commitments and, as a result, have enough time to keep in touch with those people they don't meet every day. What's more, the old don't usually visit a lot of new places where they can meet new people and make new friendships, or even if they do visit such places, they still prefer to communicate with the people they trust. Though, there is no doubt that old friends are also important for the young as being old friends with someone is like putting on an old comfy pair of boots. So, no new friends can be a replacement for friends we've shared a hundred experiences with.

6. Which is more important, to maintain old friendships or make new friends?

I guess maintaining an old friendship is much more important than making a new one as your old friend knows you and understands you better than a new one does. So your old friend knows how to make you feel good or sad because they've had years of watching your reactions to certain situations. Your old friend was there at that family party, they remember the heartbreak you felt when you broke up with your first love and how it changed you. There aren't many more enjoyable evenings than the ones you spend with people you've known forever, where every question starts with 'remember when'. You might be a high-flying banker or CEO now, but remember when you fell over on the bus and face-planted in front of everyone... Or the time you had such a good night out on holiday that you narrowly missed your flight home...

Topic 21: Toys, kids and ads (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. Do you think some parents spend too much money on toys?

Definitely. Some parents spend way too much money on toys. And there are lots of reasons for this. Some parents feel guilty that they spend too much time at work and don't spend quality time with their children. So they think buying lots of expensive toys is a good way to compensate for this. Some parents want to keep their children occupied for as long as possible when they find themselves too tired, too overwhelmed or too overstretched to spend quality time with their kids. Also, there are some parents who believe this is the best way to show love to their kids. They are convinced that the more toys they buy, the more loved their kids will feel. Oh, and some parents just give into their child's whims. Some children want something and throw a tantrum for it, and the parents give in and get the item. Children quickly figure out that a tantrum will be rewarded. And they use this strategy more and frequently. As a result, their parents spend more and more money on toys. Finally, there are some parents who had very few toys as kids, so they are determined to give their own children as much as they can.

2. Do you think advertising that targets children should be banned?

Absolutely! Children are an extremely vulnerable target audience because they are cognitively and psychologically defenseless against advertising. Children take everything they see at face value, and therefore they are easy to persuade. So if the ad says that it is a Snickers that satisfies hunger best, they are likely to opt for a Snickers rather than healthy snacks. They quickly get used to consuming unhealthy food, and then they become adults who lead an unhealthy lifestyle. Also, children are not able to understand the persuasive character of advertising messages. However, they absorb these messages like a sponge. This may cause changes in children's behavior. For example, some children make excessive demands on their parents for the products they see in ads. especially if these products were advertised by their favorite cartoon or film characters. And some kids even have temper tantrums in public if their parents refuse to buy this or that thing.

3. Do you agree that the fact that children are targeted by many companies as potential consumers spoils their childhood?

Unfortunately, I have to agree that advertising pressure negatively affects kids' well-being, stealing their attention from simple kids' joys and drawing them inferior to their peers and changing their behavior either causing tantrums or just making them feel uncomfortable. In the worst case scenario, it can even make them imitate specific adult behaviors. I mean the necessity to make a choice about what

to buy or getting at peace with the fact that they should refuse from what they want to get.

4. What toys are popular with boys and girls in your country now?

Well, boys adore gadgets such as smartphones and tablets, tech toys and, of course, radio controlled toys which are a great deal of fun to play with. They also enjoy getting toy cars, building and construction sets, different ride-ons and board games as presents. While girls give more preference to something more creative and intimate such as arts and crafts kits, collectibles, dolls and plush toys as well as something emphasizing their femininity, for example, clothes, accessories and beauty gift sets.

5. How do toy companies make children collect their range of toys?

Well, by making toys that replicate what kids like, I guess. Children like bright, attractive toys. What is more, they like to enjoy the anticipation aspect. As a result, companies create attractive toy lines packed in gift boxes which establish the feeling of anticipation kids experience when they are about to open the box. One more trick toy companies use is selling toys at an affordable price for customers. The more affordable the toys are, the more toys from the range kids will collect. Well, and of course, toy companies use a number of marketing tricks to motivate kids to have a complete collection of toys such as putting a picture of a complete collection into each toy box, targeting kids with toy unboxing videos and showing kids that it's cool to have a complete collection by promoting their range of toys with bloggers and opinion leaders.

6. Do you think some parents spend too much money on toys?

Definitely. Some parents spend way too much money on toys. And there are lots of reasons for this. Some parents feel guilty that they spend too much time at work and don't spend quality time with their children. So they think buying lots of expensive toys is a good way to compensate for this. Some parents want to keep their children occupied for as long as possible when they find themselves too tired, too overwhelmed or too overstretched to spend quality time with their kids. Also, there are some parents who believe this is the best way to show love to their kids. They are convinced that the more toys they buy, the more loved their kids will feel. Oh, and some parents just give into their child's whims. Some children want something and throw a tantrum for it, and the parents give in and get the item. Children quickly figure out that a tantrum will be rewarded. And they use this strategy more and frequently. As a result, their parents spend more and more money on toys. Finally, there are some parents who had very few toys as kids, so they are determined to give their own children as much as they can.

7. Some people say that adults can learn a lot from playing with kids. Do you agree?

Absolutely! I think the most important thing that adults can learn from playing with children is to be fully present in the moment. For example, I often find myself thinking about problems and many other things while doing something. I mean if I do something, I'm supposed to be focused on this activity. But very often I can't help thinking about other things. So I cannot truly enjoy that activity. When children play games, they stay in the moment. And the only thing they think about is that very game. While playing, children aren't planning what they have to do next, what they have to remember and where they need to go, who they need to call. So I think that adults can learn to focus on what is happening now. Another thing adults can learn from playing with kids is to be happy for no reason and enjoy little simple things. Also, children can teach adults not to be afraid to try new things. Once we reach adulthood, we stop taking risks and only go for things that seem safe. And I'm more than sure that this limits us from seeing and experiencing wonderful things, and prevents us from learning or doing something really exciting. Finally, adults can learn to express them freely and sincerely like children do.

Topic 22: Organizing things (topic for all test dates till 31 August 2022)

1. How can parents help children to be organized?

The first thing parents can do to help their kids get organized is teach them to break school projects or household chores into smaller, more manageable steps. This will show children that each project has a beginning, middle and end, which can make projects look less overwhelming and less scary. Another thing parents can do is encourage their kids to make checklists and todo lists as this will let kids check off their accomplishments as they go and see how many more tasks they have to complete and if they have enough time to do it. Also, I think it's a good idea for parents to help kids create a regular schedule as well as teach them to think ahead, reviewing their plans for the next day together and planning how to handle things if a change comes up in the schedule.

2. What factors do parents consider when choosing a gift for children?

Well, to my mind, the first factor parents take into account is the occasion. Keeping it in mind, they then set the budget and get to the next important factor which is the needs of their child. Thinking about the needs of the kid's parents also think about

their kids' likes and dislikes, their interests at that specific period of time, their habits and, of course, their dreams. Considering all of them, parents make their final choice, usually balancing between what a child really wants and needs. I guess it happens this way, at least in the families with kids that I know.

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